Camp Horde for the Lord

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37602166.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Religious Guilt, church camp au, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Pining, Repression, Verbal Abuse, Adora is so in denial she's basically a queen in Egypt now, Mild Transphobic Language, Internalized Homophobia, Homophobia, Transphobia, Angst with a Happy Ending

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Part 1 of Camp Bright Moon

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Camp Horde for the Lord

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

It's the final summer before Adora Weaver goes off to college and she's excited to be the head cabin counselor at Camp Horde for the Lord. Her best friend at camp, Catra, makes her feel confused sometimes but she just knows she can do her best to please the Lord. Can't she?

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

Adora gets ready for the arrival of the new campers.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora woke up bright and early and stared at the bare rafters of the cabin. The early morning air coming in through the open windows was almost cool, especially compared to the furnace the air would be shortly after noon. It carried with it the smell of the river at the bottom of the bluff the camp was built on and as she sat up in the bed, throwing off the thin sheet, she thought about the camp on the other side of the river. She said a quick prayer as she did. Camp Bright Moon was widely rumored to be a den of depravity and sin. At least that's what the counselors had told her growing up when she came to Camp Horde for the Lord and now that she was a counselor herself, she made sure to pass that knowledge on.

Adora checked the old clock on the nightstand and thought about the campers that'd show up later that morning and what activities she'd do with them. She was in charge of a whole cabin for the first time that year, having been given the honor over her friend Catra. Catra had complained to her about it, saying she only got it because Adora had announced she was going to Heavenbound College and Catra had only been able to go to a local secular community college.

Adora twisted the silver ring on her left finger as she thought about Catra. The purity ring had been given to her by her mother in a special ceremony at her church back home years before. She remembered how special she'd felt that day as all the parents smiled at her and congratulated her mother, Ms. Weaver, on what a perfect child she was as she promised to wait for the perfect guy to marry.

That'd been an easy task for her she'd found out. No guy really interested her. The summer before she'd briefly dated one of the other counselors, Kyle, but that hadn't been any big deal for her. Dating at the camp basically meant they held hands and hung around together. Kyle was good for that. He was bumbling and friendly and he'd made her laugh but she'd never felt anything for him like she thought she should. Catra though made her confused. Adora considered Catra her best friend even though they lived in separate towns and only saw each other over the summers. In between, they wrote to each other through the whole year.

Adora gripped the ring tight as a thought of Catra's face, her beautiful brown skin full of freckles, drifted through her mind and she thought about gently touching it and tracing a line from freckle to freckle. As the thought drifted through her head, she forced herself to stop thinking about it. The thought felt wrong. Catra was her friend and she shouldn't feel that way about her. She said a prayer, asking for guidance, as she stood up and grabbed her shower bag. She shoved guilt away that she always felt when she said the prayer because she kept asking for guidance instead of asking to take the feelings away. She wouldn't even admit to herself that she never could bring herself to ask that.

“Hey, Adora.”

Adora jumped as she heard Catra’s voice and turned to see her looking in the window through the bug screen. Catra was her camp nickname, so called because her name was Catrina and she constantly wore a headband with cat ears on them pushing back her bushy hair. She’d won a set in some contest the first year she’d been at camp and had worn them the rest of the time that year. People started calling her Catra then and the next year she’d shown up with another set. Since then, she’d done it every year.

“Sheesh, just go creeping up on a person,” Adora said. “What are you doing out and about?”

“Well, I don’t start my shift over at the barn until this afternoon so I’m free,” Catra said. “Want to go hang out at the beach?”

“I can’t,” Adora said as she held up her shower bag. “I gotta get a shower and then get ready for the campers.”

“The campers aren’t going to be here for hours!” Catra said with a sigh. “You’ve got time! Come on!”

Adora slipped on some flip-flops and went out the door. She loved the sound the gravel walk made under her feet as she started towards the bath house just across from the little semicircle of cabins.

“Catra, I stink,” Adora said. “I’m funky. I am in need of cleansing.”

“Adora, you smell fine. Pretty good in fact,” Catra said and then suddenly looked shy. “I mean, it’s camp. We’re all going to be funky so you smell fine compared to the normal funk.”

Adora laughed as Catra followed her along.

“Tell you what. I’ll make it quick and we can grab breakfast and at least sit on the benches,” Adora said, referring to a popular hang out spot just outside the little camp store.

“You mean the ones that are covered in paint right now?” Catra said.

Adora rolled her eyes as she said, “We can sit against a tree there then.”

Catra looked at her for a moment and then said, “Alright. But hurry! I know you’re going to be trying to be all extra top notch for the new assignment but I want some time with my bestie.”

“Well go grab breakfast then!” Adora said. “You know what I want. I’ll see you there.”

Catra waved as she went off and Adora took her shower, whistling a little as she did, thinking about how she wished her friend could come with her to college. As she went back to her cabin to grab her boots and change out of her night clothes, she thought about sharing a dorm room and staying up late laughing and chatting with Catra and just how great it could be. A little traitorous voice, what Adora thought of as demonic temptation, kept trying to be heard but she just hummed her favorite hymn to drown it out as she pulled her boot laces tight and tucked her camp t-shirt into her shorts. She took one last look at herself in the mirror by the door with the phrase, "You are fearfully and wonderfully made!" tacked on it in glittery letters before she was off with her clipboard.

"Beginning to think you'd ditched me," Catra had said as Adora walked up to her shortly afterwards. Adora slid down the big cottonwood tree and sat down next to her.

"It's been like ten minutes," Adora said with a roll of her eyes.

"Ten minutes I didn't get to spend with my bestie and trying to fend off Rogelio there," Catra said. Rogelio, one of the water instructors, rolled his eyes at Catra as he went past. "Pure thoughts, Rogelio! Let the light in!"

Adora blushed as she said, "Don't joke like that. You'll get in trouble."

Catra pushed Adora's shoulder as she handed Adora a wrapped breakfast sandwich.

“Whatever. Here, got your favorite,” Catra said. Adora grabbed the ham, egg, and cheese sandwich and unwrapped it. She took a deep breath as she did, taking in the smell of camp cooking that never seemed quite the same anywhere else, before almost inhaling the sandwich.

“Thank you,” Adora said between bites.

“Sheesh, your mom not feeding you or something?” Catra said.

“No! Just nothing beats a camp breakfast sandwich. There’s just something about them,” Adora said.

“It’s the aging process,” Catra said sagely.

“What aging process?” Adora said.

“You know… them buying the food when it’s out of date,” Catra said with a grin.

“Stop it! They do not!” Adora said with a laugh. Catra just shrugged as if it was common knowledge.

“I’m just saying,” Catra replied. “So, what’s the plans for the big new head cabin counselor today?”

Adora smiled as she picked up her clipboard.

“OK, meet kids at 10:30am. Get them sorted out into cabins and then get them to the cabin to drop off their luggage. Lunch promptly at 12:00pm followed by a tour of the camp. Hey, I should see you then at the barn!” Adora said.

“I know. Swiftie will be thrilled to see you,” Catra said with a grin. Adora gave a happy smile as she thought of her favorite horse and went on.

“Anyway, swim check at 3:00pm followed by first craft time at 4:00pm. Dinner at 5:00pm…,” Adora said as Catra cut her off.

“I know then free time then evening chapel, then evening game, then in bed early at 11:00pm,” Catra said as she sighed. “You know, one good thing about losing out on the cabin counselor job is at least I don’t have to keep your hours.”

That was one thing Adora didn’t like but wouldn’t admit. Some nights they’d keep going until midnight or one in the morning, occasionally even later, to turn around and be up again at 6:00 am. She remembered when she came for just two weeks as a

camper how tired she was at the end. She also remembered going home how she'd felt like she'd been purified by holy fire, her mind exhausted but her soul alight. However, doing the same hours as a counselor all summer was a bit harder but they at least got a break every other week.

"It's not so bad," Adora said. "I kind of like it. Really sharpens up my faith."

Adora didn't see Catra give her a strange look for a moment before she bumped her with her shoulder.

"You are pretty holy," Catra said. "Especially in your shorts. I can't believe you went out with a hole that big in them."

"What?! Where!?" Adora said as she jumped up and tried to see what Catra was talking about. She stopped when she heard Catra laughing.

"Oh, ha ha, very funny," Adora said.

Catra stood up, picking up the few bits of trash from their breakfast and throwing them away. A sign hung over the trash can that read, "God loves His creation so don't trash it up!"

"You wanna walk with me to the barn?" Catra said as she dusted off her hands.

“Sure,” Adora said. “At least part way. I gotta go by the director’s office here in a bit.”

Catra shrugged, not saying anything more, as the two started walking. The sun was up and shining off the river as they walked along the bluff above it. They could see the docks for Camp Bright Moon across the river and a few people sitting on the end of it.

“You know, I heard they do co-ed cabins,” Adora said, her voice low and full of scandal. “And listen to… you know, rock and rap music and stuff.”

Catra shrugged as she went along.

“Yeah, I heard that too. Whatta you think that’s like?”

Adora looked out again at the camp as she shrugged as well.

“Hadn’t given it a thought really,” Adora said. “I just wish we could save them for the Lord.”

“Uh, yeah,” Catra said as she looked away. “That’d be great.”

Adora caught the tone in her voice and looked at her.

"You alright?"

"I'm fine. It's just too early still," Catra said. "There's the turn on the trail for the barn. I'll see you at lunch or when your tour group comes around."

"OK," Adora said. "Hug?"

Catra froze for a second but then plastered a smile on her face.

"Sure."

Adora hugged, holding her tight, before letting go.

"See you soon," she said as she started walking. She shook her head, clearing out a thought, as she walked along by herself. Soon she was at the office, a big sign over the door declaring it was Horde Prime's office. She noticed the sign had been repainted in bright white letters on the pine board it was etched into. The title was for the head of the camp and when she'd first started coming, the head had been a tall thin guy who pretty much stayed quietly in the office and didn't bother much with the actual activities, leaving that up to the head counselors of the time.

The man who held the title now, the current Prime, was a man with a big smile, a booming voice, and eyes that never seemed to miss any chance to point out sin. He always greeted the campers by telling them his name, which was Joshua and then reminding them that Joshua had led the Jews into the Promised Land, and that he was there to do the same for them in the name of the Lord. Adora always felt bad when she met him because she knew he had been placed in a position of authority over her but for some reason she couldn't place, she didn't like him very much. She gave a silent prayer asking for strength to accept his authority as she entered the office.

"Well hello, Adora Weaver! It's so good to see you this morning!" Joshua said with a big smile. Adora saw a small poster behind his desk with a picture of a generic potter working at a wheel with some shattered pots around him and one beautiful one on the wheel. A Bible verse was printed at the bottom.

"Hello, sir," Adora said as she turned to look at him.

"Do you like my new poster?" Joshua said.

"I do," Adora said and felt guilty because she knew it was close to a lie.

"Does my star Bible Quiz champ know that verse?" Joshua said, leaning forward a little.

Adora nodded as she said by rote memory, "What if God, willing to shew his wrath, and to make his power known, endured with much longsuffering the vessels of wrath fitted to destruction: And that he might make known the riches of his glory on the vessels of mercy, which he had afore prepared unto glory. Romans 9:22-23, King James Version."

Joshua gave a delighted grin as he gave a quick clap.

"Look at you! Getting the old King James out on me are you!? I'm impressed! Not many young adults like yourself bother with the harder language there. It shows good character before God."

Adora nodded as she blushed and a little part of her preened at the compliment.

"I'm going to start learning Greek at school this next semester as well," Adora said, trying not to sound like she was bragging. "I hope to be a good scholar of the Word."

Joshua nodded as he said, "That's good. It'll be of use when you raise up your children in the Word of God. Just don't fall prey to the temptations of the Devil when you study and begin to question. I've seen many good people fall to the Devil because of the thoughts he slips into our minds."

"Oh, no sir," Adora said, shaking her head. "That's one reason I'm here, to make sure I'm spirituality outfitted with the Armor of God

for what’s to come.”

Joshua gave an easy smile as he said, “At least you’re going to a good Christian college. They’ll help keep you on the right path. Now let’s talk about the day's work.”

Adora sat down as she pulled her clipboard out and began to take notes. As they finished up, Joshua said, “And I’m changing your kids. Instead of the eight to nine year olds, I’m going to give you the eleven to twelve year olds.”

Adora looked up, surprised, as she said, “Oh. I… wasn’t expecting that.”

“I know you weren’t but I think you can handle it. That means you have to give them the Talk,” Joshua said. “Do you think you can do that?”

Adora remembered when she’d received the same talk. Her counselor had taken her and the rest of her cabin out to a remote spot at the camp and then sat down and told them about the evils that were about to tempt them and befall them as they moved into maturity. She’d told them about boys and the terrible things they’d want and the lure of immorality and how the world would try and tell them it was alright, it was just love or no one’s business but there’s, and it'd all been in very blunt language that had left everyone in her cabin uncomfortable, blushing, and staring at the ground. Adora took a deep breath and nodded.

“I can,” Adora replied.

“Good. I know the stuff you probably hear these days from your unsaved peers but Adora, I know I can count on you to help these kids grow up right,” Joshua replied as he picked up a folded piece of paper and handed it to her. “Make sure you hit these points.”

Adora opened the paper to see a bullet point list. It had points such as the Homosexuality, Abstinence, Pornography, and Occult Dangers. She blushed a little but nodded and tucked the folded paper onto her clipboard.

“I know it’s awkward,” Joshua said. “Just remember that you’re a light on the hilltop for these children.”

“I can do it and thank you for entrusting me with this, sir,” Adora said.

“You’ve got this,” Joshua said as he stood up from behind his desk. He walked over to Adora and clamped his hands onto her shoulders and gave a few quick squeezes. Adora hated it when he did that but she just smiled.

“Thank you, sir. I’ll do my best to live up to your expectations,” Adora said.

“They’re not my expectations, they’re the Lords,” Joshua said. “You’re a shepherd for these children. They’ll look up to you and any failure you have will affect them and possibly lead them down a path that ends in Hell. Never forget that.”

Adora felt her gut tighten and her heart start to race a little as she kept her smile plastered on her face.

“I will not,” Adora said.

Chapter End Notes

Hello and welcome to my first AU! I've always had a soft spot for summer camp AU's. Something about summer camp in real life always felt a bit like a little moment out of time anyway and I feel the format of summer camp lends itself to interesting stories. That being said, I picked church camp as my AU because the show, of course, has the religious tones, particularly with Horde Prime, and because it's a story I want to tell because of my own memories of church camp as a repressed teenager. The little talk Adora has to give that I mentioned up there? That happened to me, at that age, and it was so much worse than I put here. Graphic would be the way I would describe it.

Anyway, I've been working on this off and on since last summer and since I finished my big fic, I've got back to it. This is going to be in chapters, I have no clue how long it's going to be, and it's not going to be on any kind of steady update schedule like my other stuff. Let's ride shall we?

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

The campers arrive. Adora starts showing them around camp while Catra had a conversation with her friend at the stables.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had the thought of being responsible for the kid's spiritual well-being ringing in her head when the buses pulled up promptly at 10:30 am as all of the cabin counselors stood under big crosses that had cabin numbers nailed to the middle of them. One of the adult counselors, Octavia, began walking down the bus lines helping kids who had lost their sheet of paper saying where to go or to just answer questions. Kyle hopped off of one of the buses and waved at Adora and then went jogging over to Rogelio. Adora grinned as she watched the intricate handshake the two friends had concocted to greet each other, complete with hugs, hand slaps, fist bumps, and chest bumps. Then she was distracted by a girl in pigtails that came up to her.

"Are you Ms. Adora?" the girl asked.

"That's me!" Adora said with a huge smile. "What's your name?"

"I'm Melanie," the girl said.

Adora went down her list and saw she had two kids named Melanie.

"Are you Melanie Mendlehossen or Melanie Lino?" Adora said.

"Lino," the girl said emphatically. Adora made a check on her list.

"Welcome to Cabin #8!" Adora said. "Is this your first time at camp?" Melanie nodded and Adora went on. "OK, quick question, Melanie. What's your favorite Bible verse?"

Melanie's eyes went a little big before she stumblingly said, "Uh… for God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life."

Adora gave Melanie a fist bump while she said, "John 3:16! A classic for a reason. Oh, and we got another one here! Hello! This is Melanie and I'm Cabin #8's counselor, Adora! What's your name?"

And so it went until Adora had twelve girls around her. Most of them knew each other from before and were immediately chatting as Adora made sure the few who were new got included. Then Joshua blew an air horn and everyone quieted down as they turned to where he'd climbed up on top of one of the buses so he could see out over everyone as he began to talk.

“Hello and glory be to everyone! Welcome to Camp Horde for the Lord! I am Joshua and I am named for the one who showed the Jews into the Promised Land and I’m happy to be blessed by God to be able to help show you the way to the same!”

Adora listened attentively as Joshua talked about camp rules, what to expect, and where things were. She saw Catra standing off to the side with the activities counselors, goofing off a little with one of the other stable hands named Lynda D'Ream. Lynda was a year older than Catra and Adora and had confided in the two of them the year before that she’d gotten a scorpion tattoo. Adora had been appalled but Catra had just been interested. Now Adora frowned as she watched Catra put her hand on Lynda’s shoulder with a grin.

She needs to stop goofing off, Adora thought. Then she barely managed to hear her name and realized that Joshua was introducing her as the head cabin counselor. Adora stepped forward and gave a little wave, glad she’d noticed before he’d called her name again. Adora saw Catra grinning at her and got distracted for a moment and so ended up standing out in front of everyone a bit too long. She heard a bit of a chuckle as Joshua thanked her again for showing herself and she quickly tucked herself back in with her cabin. Her face was red as she forced a smile.

Joshua finally wrapped it up with a prayer, asking God to watch over everyone, guard their thoughts from temptations and the evils of the world, and to make them strong and ready to fight the Devil wherever he may be found. The crowd broke up then and Adora got her kids around her.

“Alright, is everyone ready to see our cabin!?” Adora said. The kids all nodded and Adora looked at them in confusion for a moment. “Sorry, I didn’t hear you.”

The kids gave quiet acknowledgement and Adora stuck her hands on her hips before going, “Come on! Shout it loud enough to scare the Devil!” The kids grinned as they all shouted yes and Adora raised her hand as she started walking backwards with big marching steps. “Then follow me!”

The kids grabbed their luggage and fell in behind her. Adora grinned at the cheerful faces, although she noticed one girl looked a bit lost. Adora had seen it before when she had been an assistant counselor the summer before and knew how to handle it. Adora thought for a moment and then nodded as she remembered the girl’s name.

“Bethany,” Adora said and the girl’s eyes snapped to her. “How about you come on up here and help me lead us to the cabin?”

The girl seemed unsure for a moment but finally came up. She was hauling an old green duffel bag that seemed as big as she was and Adora fell in behind her.

“Just follow the path and take the left turns,” Adora quietly told Bethany before turning to the others. “Everyone single file behind Bethany!”

The girls all scurried up and Adora fell in at the end. Bethany kept looking over her shoulder and Adora nodded as they went through the trees. As they came to the last turn that led up to the little semicircle of cabins, Adora started stamping her feet in a solid marching rhythm, loud enough for the kids to hear. It wasn't long before they fell into step, giggling as Adora made goofy little "Hep, hep, hep," noises as she marched along.

As they got to the cabin, Adora had them go on in and each kid went running in to find their names on the bunks. They were getting ready to start swapping names around but Adora stopped them.

"Nope! No bunk swapping! We're Cabin #8 and that means each and every one of us is the other's friend! Besides, it's not like we have a lot of room," Adora said with a laugh as she hung up her clipboard over her bunk by the door. "You'll be able to talk with your old friend just as easily as your new friends! Now you've got five minutes to get your stuff put up and then we'll talk bunk rules."

The kids crammed their stuff into little open front cabinets built between the bunk beds, laughing and giggling. There were a few screeches as a couple of daddy long leg spiders scurried away from one of the cabinets and Adora laughed as she told the girls not to worry about them.

"What if they come back when we're *asleep* and try to get in our *mouths!?"* one of the girls named Abigail said with big eyes.

“They’re harmless, honey,” Adora said. “They’re just one of the Lord’s creations and I promise you they want to stay away from you. Why do you think they ran when you put your bag in there?”

Abigail looked at where the spiders had disappeared up into the rafters with a little distrust but finally just nodded her head. Adora noticed that the five minutes she had given them had turned into ten but that was as planned as she called them together and got them to sit down on the floor facing her bunk. She grabbed her clipboard and sat down with her back against the bedpost.

“Alright! Let’s get the rules down first and then we’ll talk about what we’re going to do the rest of the day. First rule, we’re all friends here. If you have a problem, please come to me. We’ll talk about it and pray it out. Second, that means no arguing or fighting. Strife is what the Devil deals in and we’re here for fun and the Lord! Third, keep your area tidy. We have two weeks here and we’ll have four surprise inspections on which we’ll be graded. If we get top marks on every single one do you know what happens?”

One of the girls raised her hand, holding it up with the other. Adora noticed the girl sitting next to her roll her eyes but chose not to say anything.

“Victoria? What do you think happens?” Adora said, picking the girl with her hand up.

Victoria gave a huge smile as she pushed her glasses up a little and said, "We get an ice cream sundae party at the end of the two weeks!"

"That's right, Victoria!" Adora said as she leaned in and high-fived the girl. "I don't know about you all but I'd love to get that party." Adora grinned as she saw the girls smile and nod. "OK, fourth rule…"

The girl sitting next to Victoria, the one who'd rolled her eyes cut Adora off then. Her name was Kaitlyn and she said, "Why do you have a rainbow on the back of your clipboard? Those are for… homosexuals."

Kaitlyn said the last word in a delighted whisper, like she was saying something so naughty but true. The rest of the girls giggled and Adora looked at the big rainbow on the back of her clipboard. The arc of the rainbow went between two big sparkly clouds and Kyle had given it to her at the end of the previous summer.

"Well, Kaitlyn, I got that last summer and while yes, the World might say that's what the rainbow is for but we all know better because Genesis chapter nine tells us it's to show God's covenant between Him and us. So I prefer to use it to remember what God has promised us and besides, rainbows are beautiful!" Adora said with a smile. She didn't mention how she used to have cut glass prisms hanging in the window because she loved watching the light glistening out into rainbows around the cabin. Someone the previous summer had said it seemed too New Age and while it'd hurt, she'd immediately taken them down and thrown them away. Now, before any of the girls could say something else, she went

on. “As I was saying, rule four is when lights are out which means that everyone is in bed except for real emergencies.”

The girls settled down as Adora went through the next few rules and then took them out to play a quick game in the courtyard between the cabin and the showers before she started them towards lunch and then the tour of the camp.

# # #

Later, at the far end of the camp, Catra helped finish unloading a hay delivery from a farmer that lived up the road. Catra had skipped lunch but that was fine with her. She could have sat with Adora but she knew she’d be paying attention to her kids for her cabin and she wouldn’t be able to speak with her much. Besides, sitting beside Adora with the whole camp around them was a special form of torture for Catra as she almost felt like everyone could read her thoughts when she was by Adora.

She shook her head and concentrated on hauling the heavy bales of hay. Catra always wondered why Joshua even bought from the farmer. Her hair was purple, shaved along the sides, and pulled back in a ponytail and was very much not what Catra thought of as someone who would ever been seen around the camp. Catra couldn’t think of a time that she’d ever seen the woman in a shirt with sleeves on.

She was an older woman named Tara, pronounced Tar-ah as she’d tell anyone who said it wrong, and she was always grinning when she brought her truck in with hay and feed every week. Catra

loved the truck. It was a big flatbed, both doors different colors from each other and the rest of the truck, dented with scratched paint and invariably with some dried mud flaking off it. The back window sported several deer skeleton head stickers, the name of some secular band that Catra had never heard of, and a sticker for the local farm co-op. She didn't know why but if she had thought about it, she'd have said that it felt like freedom to her for some reason.

"Come on, woman!" Tara said as she walked past Catra with a bale of hay in each hand. "You can do better than that!"

"Hey, some of us don't bench press steers every day for fun," Catra shot back at her as she sat down the one bale of hay she had carried over to the front of the barn. Lynda came out from where she'd gone inside with some of the hay and grinned at Tara as she grabbed two more and hefted them with almost no effort.

"She doesn't seem to have any issues," Tara said with a laugh.

"Well, Lynda there is just naturally buff," Catra said as she watched Lynda go back into the barn. She didn't notice Tara looking at Catra for a moment before shaking her head.

"Sure, that's the excuse," Tara said as she clapped a hand on Catra's shoulder. "Well, that should be everything."

“Yeah, OK,” Catra replied as she looked up at Tara. “Need me to sign anything?”

Tara nodded as she walked over to the truck and got a clipboard. Catra saw the brand for her farm burned into the back of the wood, a C and a W together with a rafter shape over the top of them both. She looked at the invoice on it and then handed it to Catra. Catra gave it a once over as she took a pen and signed it.

“Hey, kid,” Tara said as she took it back and separated the carbon copy and handed it to Catra.

“What?” Catra said, a little irritated at being called kid.

“If you ever need something, anything, you call me at that number on there alright?” Tara said, her voice careful. “Or just come on down to the farm if you need to, OK?”

Catra looked at her a bit confused as she said, “I mean sure but if we need something I gotta have Joshua order it.”

Tara looked at her for a moment before shrugging as she said, “No problem. Just keep it in mind.”

“Sure, whatever,” Catra said. Tara waited a moment longer and then shrugged again before waving at Lynda as she came out of the barn before getting in the truck and driving away.

Lynda came up beside her as she said, “Got it all stored.”

“Thanks, Scorpia,” Catra said with a grin.

Lynda looked around for a moment before she said in a low voice, “Come on, don’t call me that.”

Catra grinned at her as the two started walking towards the barn.

“No one else is out here right now,” Catra said. “You’re too paranoid.”

“Listen, you know the camp rules on tattoos,” Lynda said. “I could get fired and I need this job. I’m saving up to move out to live with my mom and her friend.”

“Why don’t you just go and live with her anyway?” Catra said as they started making their way down the stalls, putting hay in the feeders for the horses. “I mean, it’s your mom.”

“I know but her and her friend are struggling as it is and I want to help,” Lynda replied. Catra just shrugged. She lived in a foster home and was barely tolerated as it was so she didn’t see why she wouldn’t take the chance to go somewhere she'd actually be

wanted. Then the two stopped as they heard the sounds of faint singing coming from the trail towards camp.

"Gotta be Adora," Catra said with a grin. Lynda looked at her for a moment before going back to putting the last of the hay in for the horses.

"Guess it's the first group of the afternoon," Lynda said, trying for nonchalance and failing but Catra didn't notice.

"Yep. Well, let's go show off the barn," Catra said, spreading her arms wide to take in the structure.

Lynda and Catra stepped outside, brushing hay bits off their clothes, as Catra finally caught the words of the song right as Adora came around the corner with the kids from her cabin.

"Onward Christian soldiers, marching as to war! With the cross of Jesus, going on before! Christ, the Royal Master, leads against the foe! Forward into battle, see His banners go!"

Adora sang the song loud and happy, the kids a half beat off as they had just learned it, as they came towards them.

"Haven't heard that in a while," Lynda said.

“Spend more time around Adora. It’s her third favorite song,” Catra said with a shake of her head.

“Third?” Lynda said and gave Catra an odd look.

“Yep. It was a toss-up for a while between that and *When the Saints Go Marching In* but that’s number four now,” Catra said as she waved at Adora as she came to a stop in front of the barn. “Number two is *I’ll Fly Away* and number one is *Amazing Grace. ”*

Lynda watched her as Catra walked over and gave her friend a fist bump. Adora introduced the girls to Catra and Lynda and soon they were walking along the lines of stalls, watching the horses eat. Lynda held one of the girls up so she could pet the nose of one of them as Adora went to the stall where a white horse looked at her.

“Hey there, Swiftie,” Adora crooned as she took a few sugar cubes out of her pocket and fed them to the horse. As the horse chewed, he nuzzled at her as she petted his nose. Catra leaned against the stall with a grin as she watched Adora handle what was the wildest horse in the stables. He’d kicked his way out of several stalls before and the one he stayed in now was reinforced. After a few minutes, Adora turned to Catra.

“Didn’t see you at lunch today,” Adora said.

“Well, I got started early out here after the welcome. Then Tara had a delivery for us, and I figured I just needed to get it done so I wasn’t able to make it,” Catra said with a shrug. “Still a place for me at dinner?”

Adora grinned as she bumped her hip against Catra and said, “You know there is. I made sure you’re on our team for the game tonight as well.”

Catra looked at her with a raised eyebrow as she said, “Really? And how did that happen?”

“I’m head cabin counselor now,” Adora said with a grin. “I get to assign the activities counselors to these things.”

“What is it tonight anyway?” Catra asked as the kids started forming up around them again.

“Three legged race and Bible verse relay,” Adora replied.

Catra looked at her with a raised eyebrow as she said, “Three legged race? After last year?”

Adora rolled her eyes as she remembered a race late in the summer that had gotten a bit too competitive and saw several teams face plant and one person twist their ankle badly enough that they had to go home.

“We’ve changed the rules up. No win for speed this time. It’s pure Bible knowledge that’ll get you through,” Adora said.

“Glad I’m on your team then,” Catra said. “You know I don’t have the best memory for that stuff.”

Adora threw an arm around her as she said, “Sure you do. You said that one from Ruth was one of your favorites last year.”

Catra managed not to blush as she thought of the passage.

“Oh, yeah, that one,” Catra said. “I don’t remember it that well.”

Adora said, “I do! It was Ruth 1:16. Ruth tells Naomi, ‘Don’t urge me to leave you or to turn back from you. Where you go I will go, and where you stay I will stay…’”

Catra nodded quickly as she cut Adora off and said, “Oh, yeah, that one. Yeah, I remember now.” She turned to the girls who’d gathered around them. “Hey, kids, what do you think of the place?”

The kids piped up and said how they liked it and asked if they could go riding right then.

“Sorry, we’re not set up for riding today but your counselor here,” Catra said, giving Adora a little shake about the shoulders, “should be able to tell you when you get to come riding with us.”

Adora nodded as she said, “We’ll be out here several times over the next few weeks. Lynda and Catra here will show us the ropes and you’ll be riding like pros by the time you head home.”

Lynda stepped up as she said, “That’s right! We got a big surprise as well this year. Your overnight outdoor camp is going to be on horseback.”

The girls who were new didn’t know what that meant and Adora explained that one night during camp they’d normally hike a little ways up the river and then set up camp for the night in a field. There’d be a big bonfire with s’mores and they’d sleep outside. Then in the morning, they would have an outdoor church service before heading back. Adora had wanted to take the horses for years and had asked Joshua to let her do it for her cabin as a test. Most of the girls looked excited although Adora could see that Abigail wasn’t too thrilled about the proposition.

“Can’t wait for it,” Catra said and Adora looked at her. “What? I have to go along to help take care of the horses.”

Adora tapped her finger against her lip as she looked at her and said, “Oh, you do, don’t you? I hadn’t thought of that.”

Catra laughed as she gave her a push. Soon Adora had the girls lined up and started heading back towards the main camp. She started up another hiking song as she went and Catra leaned against the door of the barn. Lynda stood next to Catra, looking down at her as she watched Adora go.

"You really like her don't you?" Lynda said.

Catra snapped her eyes off of Adora and turned to Lynda.

"Well, yeah, she's my best friend," Catra said.

"I know. You always light up when she's around," Lynda said as Catra grabbed a broom and started sweeping the floor.

"Whatever," Catra said. "She's my buddy."

Lynda watched Catra sweep for a moment before she said, "You know, I'm your friend too."

Catra stopped sweeping and turned around to Lynda as she said, "Yeah, I know. What's going on?"

“Nothing,” Lynda said as she looked away.

“Naw, come on,” Catra said, walking over to her. “What’s up, Scorp?”

“Hey, seriously, stop that,” Lynda said looking back at her. “I shouldn’t have shown you that. You’re going to screw up and say that at the wrong time.”

Catra held her hands up as she said, “Whatever. Are you mad because I hang out with Adora?”

“No, I’m not mad. I just think, well, maybe she doesn’t appreciate you like… well, she just doesn’t appreciate you as much,” Lynda said.

Catra leaned the broom against a stable as she said, “What do you mean? She appreciates me just fine.” Lynda started to say something and then shook her head as she started to walk towards the tack rack. “No, don’t walk off. What do you mean?”

“Nothing. I’m just saying what I notice,” Lynda said.

“She’s busy,” Catra said. “She’s got a lot of stuff going on.”

Lynda just shrugged as she grabbed some tack and headed towards one of the horses.

"Yeah, you're probably right. Just forget about it, I wasn't thinking straight," she said as she opened the stall. "I'm going to take Sunray here for a walk around the paddock."

Catra watched Lynda lead the horse out and went back to sweeping. As she did, she thought about what Lynda had said. Catra knew how she felt for Adora and she thought maybe Adora felt the same. As she swept though, she had to admit to herself that maybe Adora didn't actually feel the same way. Her hands gripped the broom tighter as she went, wishing so hard that Adora would just give her a clear, unambiguous sign that she felt like Catra felt. She didn't realize she'd been standing still in the middle of the barn for a minute until she heard another group of campers coming up from outside. She tossed the broom to the side, wiped the tears that had formed in her eyes, and walked out with a forced smile to meet them.

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, I listened to Rainbow Connection for writing part of this chapter. Also, reading this to my wife who has her own church camp memories, she kept saying, "Gah! That's so cringe!" when I had Adora say things like, "Shout it loud enough to scare the Devil!"
>
> Me: But am I wrong?
>
> Her: No, but that doesn't make it any less cringey.
>
> She also started singing lyrics from the musical The Book of Mormon to me every time Adora had some moment of repressing a thought. Specifically, "Turn it off like a light switch/There it's gone/My hetero side just won."

Anyway, I hope you're enjoying this and thank you for reading!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra attend an evening chapel service.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stood next to Catra in the front row of the chapel. It had been three days since the campers had arrived and the younger kids had already had their service before the one going on at the moment. The one going on at the moment was for kids starting at eleven years old and going up. It was almost ten at night and they'd already been going for an hour with the praise and worship as Adora had her hands in the air, swaying back and forth as she sang along to the song the small band on stage was playing. The room had no A/C and all the windows were open, trying to catch a breeze, but it wasn't that large of a room and it was packed to the brim with people and so it was hot and muggy. A few fans in the rafters tried to stir the air but they might as well have not bothered.

While Joshua ran back and forth in front of the crowd, getting people to sing louder, and calling on the Lord, Catra was ready to call on the Lord herself if only to end the whole thing because she was already exhausted and knew the service would probably last at least another hour. She'd managed to avoid the last two nights with excuses about duties out at the barn but she knew that would only work so many times before she got in trouble and so she'd shown up.

Now her bushy hair was tied up off her neck but she was still sweating buckets. She wished she'd stayed on the back row with Lynda, Rogelio, Kyle, and the other activities counselors. Back there it was easier to have a joke, be a bit more relaxed, and being by the window meant a person could occasionally even get a puff of air that wasn't laden with sweat and the body heat of every single person packed into the room. However, Adora wasn't back there and Catra didn't mind putting up the discomfort to be beside her.

The song came to an end but the guitarist kept plucking a little rhythm while the drummer kept a slow beat while Joshua's voice boomed over the sound system.

"Hallelujah! Praise the Lord! Praise his Holy Name! Lord, drive out all doubts from our minds with the might of your glory! Drive out all wickedness and temptation! Wash us in the holy blood of the Lamb and cleanse us of our sins to make us worthy of You!" Joshua shouted out to cries from the crowd of amen and hallelujah as well as monophonic strings of syllables as people looked towards the ceiling and spoke in tongues. "We're all sinners and have fallen short of glory! We're all sinners who don't deserve the grace that is offered to us but that's the wonderful thing that I'm here to show you! Give yourself totally to the Lord! Accept Him into your heart and you'll know life everlasting! Reject him, go with what the World says, and you'll know nothing but the grave and the eternal fires of Hell!"

Joshua looked down at the floor and swayed for a moment and the room quieted down a little. He held his hand high over his head as he swayed back and forth and quietly said, though still picked up by the microphone in his hand, some names of God.

"Elohim, El Shaddai, Adonai… we love you, we love you, cleanse us of our sins…"

He went quiet and stayed like that for a moment before he lowered his hand and looked out at the crowd.

"I know some of us here today need healing. Whether it's spiritual or physical, I know some of you need the touch of God. I call on anyone here that needs to have their minds purged of sin and doubt, you know who you are, come to the altar! Those of you who are suffering from the demons of sickness, come down! Those of you suffering from temptations of the flesh, come down! Come to the altar, lay your problems at the feet of the Lord, and we'll gather around and lay hands on you! We'll channel the power of the Holy Ghost to wash you clean, to force the World from you! Come forward now! Don't wait! That voice in your head telling you to be ashamed or embarrassed is the Devil! Force him from your mind and come down here to be healed and lifted up into the Light!"

Catra sighed in relief as a few people went forward. She'd been waiting for this moment because she knew it was her chance to get a break. She waited another minute while Joshua worked the crowd, occasionally cutting into monophonic syllables as he spoke in tongues and hovered his hand over someone, and a few more people went forward. Finally, Catra went forward and kneeled down in front of the first of two steps that led up to the stage and leaned forward to put her elbows on the stage, looking for all the world like she was deep in prayer. What she was doing instead was taking a moment to get her eyes closed and not have to

move. The price she paid was that after a minute, two people were around her, laying hands on her and praying.

She shoved away the discomfort of having them around her and just leaned into the hands, taking the moment to let her mind drift. It wasn't possible to sleep with the noise and the heat, even if she wouldn't have gotten in trouble for it, but it was possible to just let go for a moment, let the noise of the room turn to background gibberish, and drift for a moment. It wasn't real rest but it would be enough until she was able to finally get back to her cabin. Catra had just slipped into that drift when she felt two hands touch her head, one on the side of her face and the other higher up on her hair. She knew immediately it was Adora.

A few minutes before, Adora was letting her mind focus as hard as she could on the music and the words of Joshua as he spoke. As she swayed, she occasionally felt Catra's hair brush against her arm or would occasionally gently bump against her. She was happy to be there with her friend but a little thought in her mind kept trying to distract her from the worship. She forced herself to ignore it, to pay attention to Joshua as he walked up and down and called on the Lord. She had her hands up and her eyes closed as he called on people to come down for spiritual healing and so didn't notice Catra move to the front.

The song was low and slow now as the whole room prayed. Adora opened her eyes to look at the kids in her care taking up the front row, each of them with their hands up, eyes closed, and doing as Adora did. Adora smiled to see them learn how to worship more deeply when she turned and saw two people knelt down by Catra on the stage. She didn't know why Catra was up there but Adora suddenly stepped forward and got up onto the stage, kneeling down in front of Catra and placing her hands on her head, just as

she'd learned to do for spiritual healing. Her breath caught in her throat for a moment as she felt Catra's skin under her hand and for a moment almost ran her other hand back through Catra's hair. She leaned forward and began to pray the first thing that came to mind.

"I love this woman before me," Adora said. "She's my sister in Christ and whatever afflicts her, I banish it from her in the name of Christ. Whatever troubles her I ask that it be resolved. Lord, this woman is precious to me as she is to you. She is your child as am I and as you said in Psalms, she is fearfully and wonderfully made. Raise her up! May her troubles fall! May all good things come to her and may her cup run over! In your Holy name, let this be!"

Adora leaned further forward and rested her forehead against Catra's head as she began whispering over and over, "Let this be, oh Lord God, let this be. Let this be, oh Lord God, let this be."

At first she was praying for what she'd asked, that whatever had brought Catra to the stage that night would be resolved, but as she went on, she wasn't sure what she was praying for. She just knew kneeling there on that stage that nothing else in the room seemed to matter but holding the side of Catra's face and praying to God to let whatever it was she was praying for to happen.

When Catra felt Adora's hands touch her she wasn't sure what to do. She'd heard of the touch of healing before and how it was possible to feel the power of Christ flowing through the touch of a person truly in tune with the Lord. What she was feeling now was the only thing she had ever felt that felt like that. She felt like she

was consumed by fire and yet not harmed as she heard the words start to come out of Adora's mouth.

"I love this woman before me," Catra heard Adora say and she thought her heart was going to stop. Catra didn't hear the next few things as her mind seemed to be scrambled for a moment and when she once again heard the words coming out of Adora's mouth, she heard her say, "Lord, this woman is precious to me as she is to you."

Catra knew that Adora was simply praying, she knew it didn't mean anything like she wanted, but her heart didn't want to hear that. Adora had said she loved her and when she leaned over and touched her forehead to Catra's head, Catra felt dizzy and her arms started to shake. Then she heard Adora begin to pray low, fervent and more desperate than Catra had ever heard her pray before. She heard the words spilling from Adora's lips, "Let this be, oh Lord God, let this be. Let this be, oh Lord God, let this be," and Catra began to mouth the words as well as a prayer, more sincere than any she had ever said before.

The moment seemed to last for hours and only seconds all at once and was broken when several other people came over and hands touched Adora and Catra together and Catra heard Joshua on the microphone over her head praising God for his influence through those that followed him. The moment was broken and people began to get up and move back to their seats as Joshua began to talk. Adora lingered for a moment longer before standing up.

Catra looked up to see her standing over her, her blonde hair glowing from the light behind her as the fan blades of the fan

seemed to encircle her head, and for a moment Catra wasn't sure she'd be able to stand from the dizziness in her head and the shakiness in her limbs. Adora gave her a shy smile as she held a hand down to pull her to her feet and the two finally returned to their pew.

Catra barely heard the rest of the service. She kept trying to tell herself this was just a coincidence, this was just Adora being Adora and she didn't mean it, but she kept hearing that soft, fervent litany falling from Adora's lips.

As the service let out, Catra walked out with her arm around Adora's shoulder as the two laughed about something. Catra couldn't even say what it was, she just felt joy bubbling up through her as they walked across the grass lawn in the dark. The stars overhead shone bright in the dark country sky and Catra felt like she was light enough to leap up and grab one. As they passed the swimming pool, where the camp did baptisms as well as more regular swimming, she poked Adora in the ribs with her elbow as she said, "Check that out, Mountain Dew Pool is bright tonight!"

Adora rolled her eyes at the old joke. The pool was kept scrupulously clean by Rogelio and the other counselors working at the pool but the side of the pool was painted a pale green and so at night with the pool lights on, it did look like a big pool of glowing soda. They sat down on the grass beside the pool fence after Adora got the girls lined up to play Red Rover against another cabin.

"How has no one ever broken an arm playing this?" Catra asked as they watched a kid go barreling down the slope towards a line of other kids.

“It’s not that bad,” Adora said and then they both flinched as the kid hit the linked arms of the line and went flipping over it face first into the ground. “Really.”

Catra laughed and gave Adora a shove as she said, “The fact you can say that after seeing that just means you’re really good at denial.”

Catra didn’t notice the flash of worry that shot across Adora’s face to be replaced by a smile a bit too wide.

“Whatever,” Adora said. “It’s just a game. We played it and we turned out fine.”

Catra gave a fake wince as she rotated her arm and said, “You sure? I can tell the weather is going to change soon. My old Red Rover injury is acting up.”

Adora almost said something then caught herself as she said, “Nope, not getting me with that joke again.”

“But Adora! The arm! It hurts!” Catra said, her eyes wide before suddenly bursting out into laughter. “The fact this is the first time I haven’t got you with the ol’ insert whatever injury joke is a milestone for us. You finally figured it out.”

Adora smiled and Catra felt the breath catch in her throat at the easy smile, lit by the moon and the flickering light from the water, as Adora said, “I’ve known you for years. I think I know everything about you by now.”

Catra’s smile went soft as Adora turned to look at her and Catra said, “Naw, I still have a few mysteries for you to figure out I think.”

The two locked eyes for a moment and then the moment was gone as one of the girls shouted out, “Adora! They’re not playing fair!”

Adora stood up and went to figure out what was going on. After settling the dispute, she came back as Catra stood up off the grass.

“Hey, I gotta get going. I've got an early morning getting everything ready for the camp out tomorrow night,” Catra said.

Adora stepped up and hugged Catra tight and Catra hugged her right back. They rocked back and forth for a minute before they finally broke apart.

“See you tomorrow,” Catra said as she started walking backwards, not wanting to turn away from Adora.

“Yeah, see you tomorrow,” Adora said. As Catra walked away, Adora watched her go but finally turned away as she fought down the thought that was trying to scream in her head. She gathered up the kids from her cabin, high fiving them for winning the game, and they all went off to their cabin. The girls slipped away to sleep pretty fast but Adora stayed up later than normal, staring out the window at the moon, as she quietly prayed for guidance and strength.

Chapter End Notes

> I read this to my wife and her reply was, “You’ve really got the feel for this. It's like I’m reliving some of the worst memories of my childhood.”
>
> Thank you to everyone who's been coming along on this! I'm glad you're enjoying the fic.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

> It's time for the overnight camping trip for Adora's cabin but it looks like there might be some guests along they weren't expecting.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?
>
> Note: For those following along, Adora's mother, Ms. Weaver, has a moment in this chapter so I went ahead and updated the tags on this to reflect that she's not a nice mother.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora raced across the field on Swift Wind, leaned over low as she rode, and turned as she came to the tree line at the last second. She came back towards the line of horses riding out of the tree line to see Lynda shaking her head with a smile on her face. Adora rolled up beside her as she said, “Sorry, Swiftie had to get a little energy out.”

“He still seems to have a bit,” Lynda said with a nod at Swift Wind who was prancing a little as they went along.

“That’s alright,” Adora said as she leaned forward to pat his neck. “We’ll give you another run here in a bit won’t we buddy?”

Swift Wind nickered at her and she smiled as she sat back up and turned around to watch as the rest of the horses followed the trail

through the field. Catra came out last and nudged her horse up to a trot and came up beside Lynda and Adora.

"How're we doing?" Catra said. She had her hair tied up under a handkerchief and Adora grinned to see the cat ear headband put over the top of it.

"Just running Swiftie a little," Adora said.

"Want to try trotting the girls across the meadow?" Catra asked. The kids had done a little riding already and Catra didn't have to guess Adora's response, which was an immediate yes, and so Lynda took up the rear as Catra went out in front of the kids.

"Alright, we're going to do a trot now," Catra said. "Just like we practiced the other day. Ready!? Here we go!"

Adora fell into line as the kids went past, most of them happy, a few of them nervous, but all of them doing just fine as the horses clopped along. Catra had worked hard to make sure that every horse that went out that day was tame and easy to handle because she knew that this was a test of Adora's idea of having a trail ride for the camp out. She wanted to be sure it went smoothly for her.

The kids covered the distance to the next tree line pretty quickly and as they got close, Catra slowed her horse down and got the rest to do the same. She grinned at each kid and, taking a page

from Adora's book, high fived them as they went past before riding up past them to take the front. Catra couldn't help but smile as she rode along. They were riding not too far from the river and so that meant the path they were following was surrounded by huge cottonwoods and the sun coming down through the leaves danced around as the leaves moved in the breeze.

It wasn't a long ride and they took it easy, stopping for a break and a snack halfway through the afternoon. Bethany tried to climb one of the trees to get a better look out over the field and to check out a bug she had seen and Adora could see Kaitlyn watching Bethany closely. Despite what Adora had said the first day, the girls still snipped at each other occasionally as who was considered cool at the time shifted back and forth. Adora had noticed that Kaitlyn was pretty high up the hierarchy but Bethany most certainly was not and Adora had already had to pull Kaitlyn to the side once to have a talk about how it wasn't the Christian thing to pick on someone. She hadn't caught her at it again but she knew that Kaitlyn had probably just gotten crafty about it.

"Kaitlyn," Adora said and she watched as Kaitlyn turned suddenly. "How about you help me walk the field and make sure we don't leave any trash behind?" Adora could see Kaitlyn didn't want to do anything of the kind but Adora smiled at her. "God has placed us as stewards over His creation. This is part of that and I'd love for you to help me."

Kaitlyn got up and another girl named Grace, who was always hanging round with Kaitlyn, got up without being asked and they made a quick tour around where they'd been. Kaitlyn tried to go over towards the horses where Catra and Lynda were getting them ready to go again and Adora figured she was trying to get out of the cleanup. Adora moved to be between her and the

horses as she thought about how she'd met Catra when they were only about a year younger than the girls around her at the moment.

Adora had been coming to camp since she was old enough to come at seven years old but that had been Catra's first year. She'd shown up with a few plastic shopping bags full of her stuff and clothes that didn't quite fit or match. The other girls had left her alone at first but within a day or so of being at camp, they'd started picking on her. This had led to the one and only time Adora had ever gotten in serious trouble at camp. She'd come back from the bathroom one evening to find a few of the popular girls making fun of Catra and starting to push her.

"Hey! Leave her alone!" Adora had said as she stepped up next to her.

"If you care so much about her, why don't you take her to the shower?" one of the girls said with a smug look. "She *stinks."*

"I do not!" Catra shouted back.

"Yes, you do," the other girls said and started chanting Stinky Catrina at her. Adora was about to go grab the counselor when one of the girls pushed Catra again. Catra pushed her back as Adora saw the tears in her eyes. Adora didn't hesitate. She turned and punched the ringleader as hard as she could in the stomach.

"You leave her alone!" Adora had shouted as the other girls went backing up. The ringleader had collapsed to the floor and was rolling around crying and screaming dramatically. It was at that point that the counselor had shown up. Adora got dragged to Prime's office, not Joshua at the time but the previous Prime named Henry, who'd just sighed as he rubbed his skinny arms. He'd given her a lecture on turning the other cheek and being a peacemaker but that hadn't been the worst part. The worst part had been her mother driving up the next morning.

Adora remembered getting pulled out of swimming, where Catra had been staying close to her because the other girls were still being leery around Adora but leaving Catra alone, and standing in the cold air of the office as her mother walked around her. Her floor length red dress seemed to float around her as she walked around Adora looking her up and down. She hadn't bothered to take off her large black sunglasses she'd worn in the car and Adora trembled although not entirely from the cold air of the A/C on her wet swimsuit.

"Child, I was busy with my ministry at the church," Ms. Weaver said as she finally stopped behind Adora. Adora knew from previous times of being in trouble that she was not to turn around. "Then I get a call that you've been fighting."

"Ma'am, it was because…," Adora started to say, even though she knew she should stay quiet.

"I did not ask you to interrupt me," Ms. Weaver said and Adora fought back the scared tears as she shut her mouth and just nodded. "Now, I have had to drive out here, neglecting my ministry back home because you are here not doing what you

should be doing. You should be here learning to serve the Lord and instead you're being a rebellious child."

Adora kept her eyes fixed forward as her mother moved in front of her and looked down at her. A long moment of silence stretched out before her mother leaned forward slightly. Adora didn't say anything still and finally Ms. Weaver said, "Are you going to just stand there or are you going to say something for yourself?"

"I'm sorry, ma'am," Adora said. "I was trying to protect her. She was being picked on."

"Protect who?" Ms. Weaver said.

"My cabin mate, her name is Catrina, ma'am," Adora said.

"It is not your job to do such a thing," Ms. Weaver. "If she was being picked on you should have gone and got someone of authority to handle it. The reason you are here is to learn to be a good child of God, to be a good Christian, and you're not going to do that getting into fistfights over some girl. You have a bright future if you can manage not to mess it up, which, I might add, you are doing right now. Is that what you want, to be a failure? Because you're certainly doing well at that right now."

The tears finally made their way down Adora's face as she said, "No, ma'am."

“Stop that. Wipe those away,” Ms. Weaver said with a shake of her head. “Henry has agreed to let you stay, even though he has every right to throw you out and never let you back, and I expect you to understand that you have been given grace even though you don’t deserve it. Make the most of your chance and do not make me come back out here. Do you understand me?”

“Yes, ma’am,” Adora said as she wiped the tears away as fast as she could. Ms. Weaver stepped forward and patted Adora on the shoulder.

“You were always a willful child but you have potential. Do not waste it for someone you don’t even know,” Ms. Weaver replied. “Now walk me to the car.”

Adora walked with her to the car parked behind the office and Adora noticed that her mother had put a new sticker on the back of the car. It sat above an older one that simply had the words Proverbs 13:24 on it. The new sticker said, “Love God, Love People.”

“That is a nice sticker, ma’am,” Adora said, hoping the compliment would ease the tension a little.

“Thank you,” Ms. Weaver said as she opened the door. “Pastor Jerome gave it to me as thanks for my work on the charity drive for the homeless. Remember what we spoke about.”

"I will, ma'am," Adora said. She watched as her mother got back in the car and drove off. Henry got up off the bench from where he'd been sitting outside and came over to her.

"Go on back to the pool," he said with a nod and Adora nodded, not able to speak, and went on.

The rest of her time that year went smoothly. The girls who'd been picking on Catra ignored Adora and Catra but the other girls in her cabin began to warm up. Catra won the contest that got her the ears, she got her nickname, and she began to fit in a bit more.

Now, years later, Adora was watching Kaitlyn to make sure the same thing didn't happen. Adora had a feeling that Bethany, quiet as she was, wouldn't do anything but take the punishment Kaitlyn dished out and Adora wasn't entirely sure that any of the other girls would do anything. They got everything cleaned up and Adora called out to get the girls together and to the horses.

"How much longer you think?" Adora said to Lynda as walked up to Swift Wind and patted his nose.

"Maybe an hour if we take it easy," Lynda said before pointing at the sky. "That's good too. It looks like it might get damp in a few hours if we're still on the trail."

Adora looked to see where Lynda was pointing, at clouds starting to gather in the northwest. They were already starting to build up a little into thunderheads.

"Should we go back?" Adora asked.

Lynda shook her head as she said, "Naw. The spot is high enough we don't have to worry about flooding and we'll be back in the trees so the worst of the wind shouldn't bother us."

Adora looked back at the clouds and finally just shrugged.

"You're probably right," Adora said as Catra came up behind her.

"We looking at those clouds I assume?" she said.

"Yep," Lynda replied. "Going to be a soggy night maybe."

"You think the horses will be alright?" Catra said.

"Yeah, we'll just have to check them extra careful in the morning and then when we get back to the stables," Lynda said.

Catra gave her a thump on the back and Lynda smiled as Catra said, “You’re the expert. Let’s get going then.”

They mounted up and headed on down the trail, Adora singing a song and the girls joining in. As Lynda predicted, they came out into a small field a little less than an hour later. It was mostly grass with a little dirt parking lot and rutted road, really just two ruts through the trees, that ran down to the river while a better road ran the other direction out to a regular road out of sight. Back in the trees was a makeshift corral and spots to set up for camping next to fire rings and a couple of pit toilets sat inside basic shelters with a dumpster between them sitting beside the parking lot. Leaning against the side of a van with the camp’s name and logo and a trailer behind it were Kyle and Rogelio. Adora nudged Swift Wind up to a trot and went over to the two.

“You made it!” Adora said with a smile.

“Well, yeah,” Kyle said. “We’ve actually been here for over an hour. Joshua said Rogelio could come along to help out but I think we left earlier than we needed.”

“It’s alright,” Adora said, leaning into the pommel of the saddle. “Looks like we might get a little rain so I hope you found us a good spot.”

Rogelio looked towards the clouds and shrugged. When he did, Adora saw dust all over his back.

“Hey, have you two been wrestling or something?” Adora said. Rogelio turned around with the blankest expression she’d ever seen on him. “What? You got dust all over your back.”

Kyle gave a stiff smile as he said, “Yeah, we were. Had to kill some time while we waited for you. Here, let me get that for you buddy.”

Kyle quickly dusted off Rogelio as the rest of the group gathered up around the van and trailer. Adora got down and got the rest of the group off the horses. An hour passed as they got the horses into the corral, got the saddles and such stored in the trailer and then took their stuff out of the back of the van and over into the trees by the corral. Adora showed the kids how to set up the big tarps they had into a long tent. While she did, Rogelio and Kyle were setting up a table that’d be their camp kitchen and Catra and Lynda were making sure the horses were alright after the ride.

As Adora stood up from showing one of the girls how to drive in a stake to hold the tarp to the ground, she heard talking coming from the little rutted road down to the river. She was a bit confused, as she wasn’t used to seeing people around the campsite, and walked out a little to see where it was coming from. As she did, she saw a bus coming down the road that led out to the main road and her eyes went wide. She’d only seen the bus from a distance from on top of the bluff back at camp.

Painted bright purple and with a big moon on its side, she didn’t even have to see the name Camp Bright Moon painted on its side to know who it belonged to. It parked on the opposite end of the little parking lot and a tall guy stepped out once the bus was parked. He was wearing shorts, a midriff exposing t-shirt slit up

the sides, and some tight top under the shirt that looked like a sports bra and Adora couldn't quite figure out why he'd be wearing it. Then she was distracted as a short woman with purple and black hair full of what looked like glitter came walking out of the trees with about twelve kids following her and went up to the bus.

Adora took a deep breath and went walking over. She wasn't sure what was going on, why Camp Bright Moon would be at this place that they'd never been before as far as she knew, but she was going to figure it out.

Chapter End Notes

Trans Bow! Trans Bow! Trans Bow!

I've always loved trans Bow headcanons but never used them in my fics. I realized that I 100% had a chance to do so in this fic so I jumped all over it. I don't think I have to point out who the woman with the purple and black hair full of glitter is. :)

Thank you for reading!

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Adora meets Bow and Glimmer, problems spring up at the Horde for the Lord campsite, and Adora has to take care of things.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

Note: Should note there's some transphobic language in here. Nothing horrifying but it's there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I’ve got the tents,” Adora heard the guy say to the purple haired woman, although Adora was noticing she was about her age as she approached. “I figure I’ll fire up the grill here in a minute so we can eat before the weather moves in.”

Adora got confused because the guy’s voice was a bit higher than she was expecting. The woman was about to reply when she saw Adora bearing down on the little group. She turned to the kids, a bunch of girls about the age of Adora’s cabin, and said, “Hey, kids. How about getting the tents out of the back and setting up over there?”

“OK, Glimmer!” a few shouted and they piled on the bus through the rear door to get their stuff.

“What do you want?” Glimmer said, her voice going from the nice she’d used with the kids to scorn as she turned back to Adora.

“Uh, my name is Adora. I’m from Camp Horde for the Lord and I’m just kind of curious as to what you’re doing here,” Adora said. “We’ve been camping here for years and I’ve never seen anyone else around.”

“Yeah, well it’s public land. You all don’t own it,” Glimmer shot back at her.

The guy put a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder and said, “Glimmer, come on. She’s just being curious. Hello, Adora. My name is Bow, he/him pronouns if you please.”

Adora blinked twice at the introduction. She’d heard about people telling other people their pronouns before but it was always presented as some Godless thing, of people so confused they mutilated their bodies or did it to trick the faithful into sexual immorality or just to deny God and reject the body He had given them. Adora looked at Bow, trying to figure out which of those he might be, but Bow didn’t seem like he was trying to lead her to Hell or something. He was just standing there with a smile, waiting politely to see what Adora was going to say.

“Yeah, well, Bow, you know how they treat Mom and Dad,” Glimmer said and then turned to Adora. Adora actually felt the urge to step back from the anger on Glimmer’s face. “You all have been giving us crap ever since that new guy took over. That

Joshua guy even tried to sue us! Don't think I'm going to let you bully us around just because we decided to camp here!"

"I'm not trying to bully you," Adora said. "I just… uh… I just, I guess, wanted to see why you were here."

"We're *camping,"* Glimmer said scornfully. "Just like you."

"OK," Adora said. "Sorry. I didn't mean to bother you."

"It's alright," Bow said, giving Glimmer's shoulder a little squeeze. "Thanks for coming over and saying hello."

Glimmer glared up at Bow for a moment before she turned and started towards where the Bright Moon campers were trying to get their tents up. Adora was about to leave when she had an idea.

"Hey, if you all want, we're having a church service in the morning here," Adora said. "You're all more than welcome to join."

Bow's smile got a little crooked and Glimmer froze for a moment. Adora wasn't sure what she'd said wrong but Glimmer didn't respond and walked off a little faster, her feet stomping down on the ground.

Bow just kind of nodded as he said, “Uh, thanks for offering. We’re probably going to head back early though, depending on the weather. So… um, nice to meet you.”

Adora nodded as she said, “Nice to meet you as well.”

Bow turned and followed Glimmer and Adora saw her start talking quietly and rapidly with lots of hand gestures at Bow as he caught up to her. Adora turned away and walked back across the parking lot to her campsite as Catra came up out of the trees.

“Save any souls?” Catra said and Adora didn’t catch the ever so slight sarcasm in her tone.

“Well, I did invite them to our service in the morning but I don’t think they were interested,” Adora replied.

“Can’t imagine why not,” Catra said and Adora looked at her.

“Come on, I think it’d be good for them,” Adora said. “We’re supposed to spread the Word after all.”

Catra just shrugged and started back towards the lines of tarps by the corral.

“Whatever. Anyway, we’ve just got about dinner ready,” Catra said.

“I didn’t see what the kitchen packed for us,” Adora said. “Anything good?”

Catra grinned as she said, “If you think canned beef stew and rice to stir into it is good, sure, it’s good.”

Adora’s face perked up as she said, “I love that!”

“Of course you do,” Catra said with a laugh. Then she looked up as a cool breeze blew past her. “Well let’s get the kids together to eat. I think we’re going to get that rain soon.”

As expected, the food was bland but Kyle produced a bottle of hot sauce after the prayer for the meal that helped give it some flavor. The first few drops of rain started to fall as they finished up.

“Alright, everyone toss their bowls and stuff in the trash so it doesn’t get blown around,” Lynda said as she got up.

“Go make sure everything is under the tarps as well so it doesn’t get wet,” Adora said.

“I’m going to make sure the horses are alright,” Catra told Adora as she hopped up.

“OK, don’t take long,” Adora said.

“Little water won’t hurt me,” Catra said with a grin as she went along. The rain started coming down in earnest a few minutes later and the girls, Adora, and Lynda all got up under the tarps. Catra came splashing up a few minutes after that as Kyle and Rogelio laughed and shouted at each other outside where they were getting the last of the kitchen stuff stowed away before they both disappeared into the dome tent they’d set up for themselves since it wouldn’t be proper for them to share a tent with the rest of the group.

“Horses are fine,” Catra said as she pulled her shirt over her head to put on a dry one and Adora suddenly had to look away.

“Oh, ok, that’s good,” Adora said, happy it was dim because of the heavy cloud cover so no one would hopefully notice her blushing.

“What are we going to do if it keeps raining?” Victoria asked.

“We’re supposed to head back tomorrow,” Adora said. “If it’s just a light rain, we’ll just put our ponchos on and ride back. It’s fun to ride in the rain.” Catra rolled her eyes but Adora wasn’t looked at her as she went on. “If it’s too bad though, we can ride back in the van.”

“What about the horses?” Bethany asked.

“Obviously someone will take them back,” Kaitlyn said with a disgusted eye roll. “They’re not just going to get left here.”

Adora was about to say something when Lynda jumped in and replied, “That’s right, Kaitlyn. Catra and I will get them roped together and lead them back.”

Adora watched Kaitlyn give a little superior look at Bethany but kept her mouth shut for now as the girls started chatting about something. Adora scooted up the line of tarps until she was up at the end. Catra moved up beside her and Lynda lay down so she was looking at the rain going by.

“Thought it’d be more of a storm from the way those clouds looked,” Lynda said as thunder rumbled. The wind wasn’t particularly fast either, only about fifteen to twenty miles an hour, just enough to get the trees around them moving and creaking and giving a little atmosphere to the dim light.

“Maybe we’re just catching the edge of it,” Adora replied as the rain came down a bit harder.

“As long as it’s not like that one trip we took, remember?” Catra said. Adora didn’t have to ask which trip. It had been three years

before and they'd woken up in several inches of water when the counselor hadn't noticed they were set up in a low spot. They'd spent a long, sleepless night with the whole cabin trying to keep the tarps in place as high winds had tried to whip them away. The final part of that trip had been having to hike out to a main road to get picked up because their canoes they had used had been washed away, and the road into the site they had stayed at that time had been washed out.

"Oh come on," Adora said with a grin. "We have fond memories of how close we got with everyone."

"Well, memories at least," Catra said with a laugh.

They settled down and watched the rain while the girls chatted behind them. None of the three said much and soon the sky got even darker as the rain got a bit heavier. When the girls got restless, Adora got them organized and pulled out a thick deck of flash cards. Each one had a Bible passage printed on one side and the corresponding book, chapter, and verse printed on the other. She had four teams of three and would go to each one and show them the book, chapter, and verse and the girls had to tell her the corresponding passage. Occasionally she'd switch it up and show them the passage and have them say the book, chapter, and verse. It ate up a few hours and soon what light there was faded as the sun went down and the rain started to end. Of course, as the rain ended, and the cool breeze with it, Adora noticed that the humidity was skyrocketing and there wasn't a breath of wind moving either.

"Well it'll be nice to sleep in a steam bath," Catra said as her hair fluffed up in the damp.

“At least we’re not in tents like them,” Adora said as she nodded at the faint glow of lanterns off towards the Bright Moon camp.

“Rogelio and Kyle are,” Lynda said.

“Yeah, but I saw the Bright Moon tents,” Adora said, remembering the kids running past with them. “They looked like canvas. Gotta be hot.”

“Well, either way, hopefully the bugs aren’t too bad,” Catra said and then, as if on cue, she smacked her arm as a mosquito tried to take a bite out of her.

That led to a general re-application of bug spray by everyone under the tarps, the sharp smell bringing a smile to Adora’s face as she thought of other trips, and then she began walking the girls to the bathroom by the light of her headlamp. A few of the girls had never used a pit toilet before and so it was a bit of an ordeal to get them used to it but finally Adora was walking back with the last group when she heard the argument in her camp.

When she got back into the tent, Bethany was in tears, Nicoletta, a quiet bookish girl who was pretty much Bethany’s only real friend in the cabin, was all but growling at Kaitlyn, and Lynda and Catra were doing their best to get everyone to calm down. Adora came under the tarp and gave a sharp, “What’s going on!?”

As everyone jumped in the light of a small lantern at one end of the tarp, Adora realized she had inadvertently sounded just like her mother but she pushed on.

"Why's everyone shouting?" Adora said, keeping her voice more level, and then realized that just asking a general question would probably get her a whole bunch of answers all at once. "Bethany, what happened?"

Kyle and Rogelio had both got out of their tent and were crouched down looking at Adora as Bethany just shook her head and wiped her eyes as she replied, "Nothing. It's OK."

"No, you're crying, something happened and I won't take a 'nothing happened,'" Adora said. "Remember what the first rule I told you was? We're all friends and this isn't how friends act. I want this settled now."

Catra looked at her and was about to say something when one of Kaitlyn's friends, Melanie Mendlehossen, spoke up.

"Bethany was being mean to Kaitlyn," Melanie said.

"She was not!" Nicoletta said, her red hair bordering on orange poofing out around her head like a visual representation of her anger. Catra, who knew what to look for, put a hand on her shoulder to keep her in place. "Kaitlyn called Bethany a lesbo!"

Adora didn’t notice Catra and Lynda’s faces go stock still as she spoke.

“Kaitlyn, is that true?” Adora said and Kaitlyn looked around and decided she had the support of those that mattered. She still muttered a little as she spoke.

“Yes, I did,” Kaitlyn said and then got a little defiant. “Because she is!”

Catra had to pull Nicoletta back as she tried to go for Kaitlyn this time and Adora said, “Enough! No one here is a lesbo or a homosexual of any kind!” Catra and Lynda’s eyes flicked towards her and Kyle and Rogelio looked down and did their best not to cough. “That’s a serious accusation, Kaitlyn, and you need to apologize for it to Bethany and I mean right now.”

Kaitlyn started to open her mouth and then saw the look on Adora’s face and looked at Bethany.

“I’m sorry for calling you a lesbo,” Kaitlyn said and then paused before going on. “Even if you act like one.”

“Kaitlyn!” Adora snapped at her and Kaitlyn realized she’d crossed a line and hung her head.

“I’m sorry, Bethany,” Kaitlyn said. Nicoletta started to say something and Adora shook her head.

“No, we’re done here. Nicoletta, get up there,” Adora replied, pointing towards the end of the tarp away from Kaitlyn’s friends. “Kaitlyn, I want you to go with Catra and stand by the van and wait for me. Bethany, come with me please. Lynda, can you watch the rest for the moment?”

Lynda was looking at Adora with a face Adora couldn’t quite place and Catra was looking away from her but Lynda finally nodded and said yes. Kyle and Rogelio went back to their tent as Catra took Kaitlyn out and Adora walked with Bethany over to the corral. Adora turned her headlamp off as they stood there in the dark for a moment.

“Are you ok?” Adora finally said.

“I’m ok,” Bethany said and Adora could hear her sniffling a little still.

“Do you want to talk about it?” Adora said.

“No,” Bethany said and Adora could hear a hint of obstinance in her voice. She thought about pushing it but finally just shook her head.

Adora started to say, “She’s just…,” and then cut herself off.

Adora was going to say that Kaitlyn was just teasing her because she was insecure and it made her feel good and Bethany should just ignore her. Then she realized that more than likely didn’t matter to Bethany. She was still getting teased and bullied and Bethany wasn’t really the person she should be talking with.

“I’ll go talk with her. Go on back to the tarps and let me know if she doesn’t leave you alone, ok?” Adora said.

Adora saw a faint head nod in the dark and then Bethany was walking away, a tiny flashlight in her hand lighting the ground ahead of her. Adora sighed as she turned around and leaned against the corral. She looked around at horses and it took a moment for her to realize she didn’t see the white coat of Swift Wind. She snapped her headlamp back on and looked, wondering if maybe he was behind another horse but they all just kind of looked up at her and it didn’t take more than a moment to do a head count and realize he definitely wasn’t in the corral.

If it’s not one thing, it’s another, Adora thought as she made her way over to the van. Kaitlyn was standing with a pout on her face and Catra was leaving against the grill of the van. Before she could even say anything, Kaitlyn started to talk.

“Adora, she started it…,” she began to say

"No, I don't want to hear it," Adora said as she took her headlamp off and let it hang from her hand so it wouldn't be in Kaitlyn's face. "You've been picking on her since she first got here. I've already talked with you once about this. 'Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called the children of God.' Does that sound familiar?" Kaitlyn reluctantly nodded and Adora went on. "So does what was going on in there look like peacemaking? No, it doesn't. It looks like anger and strife and even though you might not intend it that way, those are the tools of the Devil."

Kaitlyn was frowning but she finally blurted out, "But she's always hugging Nicoletta and hanging around her!"

"Catra and I hug all the time! It's a perfectly friendly greeting between women who are children of God! Do you think we're lesbians?" Adora said and again missed the look that crossed Catra's face as she saw Kaitlyn shake her head. "I don't know why you dislike her but it is not your job to judge her. I'm not giving you another chance. You *will* leave her alone or I *will* transfer you to another cabin away from your friends. Do you understand?"

Kaitlyn had her arms tightly around her and nodded as she said yes with downcast eyes.

"I want you to go back to the tarp and go to bed," Adora said. "You're done for the night. Catra, I have to talk to you for a moment."

Catra loaned Kaitlyn her flashlight to make her way back and when she'd walked off, Catra said, "Adora…"

She hesitated and then stopped as Adora leaned back against the grill next to her with a sigh.

"I hate having to do that," Adora said as she covered her eyes for a moment and then looked at Catra. "On top of all of this, Swiftie got out."

"What? How!?" Catra said, the words she wanted to say to Adora leaving her head.

"I don't know. The gate was closed. Jumped it for all I know," Adora said. "I'm going to go look for him."

"I'm coming along," Catra said immediately.

"No, you stay in case he comes back," Adora said. "He likes you. Just let Lynda and the guys know what I'm doing."

Catra nodded. It wasn't the first time they'd had to chase him down.

"Let me get you a lead out of the back then," Catra said as she got into the van and rummaged around for a moment before coming out with the lead. "Don't stay out long. I'll worry about you if you do."

Adora took the lead from her and then threw her arms around her in a hug.

“Thanks, Catra,” Adora said with a sigh. “I don’t know what I’d do without you.”

Catra hugged her back tightly. There was so much she wanted to say to her but she couldn’t get it out and so she tried her best to say what she could with a hug.

Chapter End Notes

> I know everyone was probably expecting more Bow and Glimmer but I promise, we're not done with them yet. Thank you for reading so far and I hope you're ready for more! This is turning out to be way longer than I expected but that's alright, I'm enjoying it.

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Adora goes looking for a horse.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora started by the corral. She found divots in the mud near the fence and figured out pretty quickly she had been correct; Swift Wind had jumped the fence. She wasn't really surprised. She'd seen him clear a fence before and had joked before that she thought he could fly sometimes. Now she began to follow the tracks through the mud by the light of her headlamp. Little trails crisscrossed all through the trees and she was glad the rain had fallen or it would have made it more difficult, or impossible, to follow the tracks. However, because she was looking down, Adora didn't notice she was getting close to the Bright Moon camp until she found herself suddenly lit by the beam of a flashlight.

"I told you she was sneaking around out here, Bow!" Adora heard a voice say as she looked up and put her hand up in front of her face.

"Yes, Glimmer, you're very right," Bow replied. "Could you take the light out of her face now?"

The flashlight beam pointed at the ground and Adora could now see the two people she'd talked to earlier standing next to a large

tree.

"Uh, I'm not sneaking around," Adora said and realized just how close to their campsite she was now with the tents only a few dozen feet away from the trail she was walking along. "One of our horses got out and I'm trying to find him."

"Told you that was a horse I heard," Bow said with a grin as he looked at Glimmer.

"Fine, whatever," Glimmer replied with a roll of her eyes. "She's looking for a horse."

"You heard him!? How long ago?" Adora said.

"Maybe right after the rain ended?" Bow said.

Adora sighed as she looked up at the sky and said, "Great, he's got a head start."

"You want our help?" Bow asked and Adora pretended she didn't see Glimmer giving him a look of "What the hell!?" while kicking his foot.

"I don't want to be a bother," Adora said. "Really."

“No bother,” Bow said with a smile while Glimmer glared at Adora with a look that said her existence was a bother.

“Um, ok, I guess,” Adora said. “If you don’t mind.”

“I gotta stay with the kids. See you later, Bow,” Glimmer said, glaring at Adora before handing Bow the flashlight and walking off without waiting for an answer.

“She doesn’t like me,” Adora said after a moment.

Bow hemmed and hawed for a second before he said, “She doesn’t like your camp. I’m sure she’d like you if she got to know you.”

Adora looked at the figure moving through the dark and felt like if Glimmer had felt like it she could have just plowed through the trunks of the trees in her irritation. She turned back to Bow as she said, “I’ll take your word for it.”

Bow laughed and started walking with her. As they did, it suddenly crossed Adora’s mind that she was walking out into the woods with a man by herself. She’d heard plenty of horror stories about what secular people would do in these situations and then it occurred to her that maybe Glimmer was mad at her because she thought Adora was going to try and steal what seemed to be her

boyfriend from her. Her face burned hot as she said, "Ummm, I just wanted to say, you know, thank you for this but I really am just looking for my horse. I'm not looking for a boyfriend or wanting anything like that."

Bow looked sideways at her for a moment before suddenly realizing what Adora was saying. He surprised her by laughing.

"No, that's alright. That's not why I offered to help you. Besides, Glimmer and I are a couple and we're happy together," he said.

Adora followed the tracks in silence for a moment as she thought about a couple out in the woods without any kind of chaperone along. That was half the reason that Kyle and Rogelio were along on the trip with them, to give them some kind of male chaperone.

"So… uh, have you two been together long?" Adora asked.

"As a couple? Naw. This is our first summer together for that. She and I were in the same cabin together when I started coming to Bright Moon about eight years ago," Bow said. Adora nodded. It just confirmed the knowledge she had of Bright Moon having co-ed cabins.

"I switched cabins a couple of years later after…," Bow hesitated and looked at her before going on. "Well, just a couple of years

later but we still hung out. Then we got into the counselor thing and now we're here."

Adora walked along, head down looking at the tracks, as she tried to think of what to say. Bow walked along with her and finally broke the quiet.

"So do you have a partner?" Bow asked.

Adora immediately thought of Catra, since Adora tried to partner with her at camp for activities all the time, and then realized he didn't mean it like that.

"Uh, no," Adora said. "That's not something I'm really interested in."

"Oh, you're ace. Gotcha," Bow said with a nod. Adora stopped and looked at him, confused.

"An ace what?" Adora said.

Bow faltered for a moment before he gave a nervous grin.

"Never mind," he said and then pointed up the trail as a way to change the subject. "Path splits up here it looks like."

Adora turned and saw that it did but more importantly, it looked like the path had headed down towards the river and the ground was now turning to sand. Which meant that the tracks were disappearing since the sand didn't really hold clear impressions. Adora walked up to the split and let out an exasperated sigh.

"Swiftie is doing this to mess with me," Adora said.

"A real pain, huh?" Bow said.

"Kind of," Adora said as she looked around, trying to figure out which way to go. "I really love that horse, he's sweet but he's also really feisty and ornery. I mean, I'm out in the woods at night trying to find him but the shepherd looks for the lost sheep and all that."

Bow just shrugged as he said, "Well, I think I can be useful now. I know this path. If you go down that way, it goes towards the river and kind of just disappears into scrub and stuff but if you go this way, it'll go up into a nice little field. I bet your horse is up there."

Adora shrugged as she said, "OK. Stay back though please, I'm not entirely sure what he'll do if he sees someone he doesn't know."

"Lead the way," Bow said with a little bow.

The two tramped their way up the trail and Adora noticed the sand didn't last long as the trail curved away from the river again. Pretty soon she saw hoof prints and then the trail went into an open field. Even from back in the trees she could see Swift Wind's white coat as he calmly chomped on the grass.

"I'll wait here," Bow whispered. Adora nodded and went out into the field.

Swift Wind looked up at her as she came out into the field. She was moving slowly, smiling, and he started to back up some.

"Come on, buddy," Adora said. "Let's get you back. We have an early morning start. Let's both get some sleep, alright?"

Swift Wind moved away from her and started to circle around behind her.

"Oh, come on," Adora muttered as she tried to get up to him.

Swift Wind froze and looked towards the trail and Adora suppressed a groan as she realized he'd probably spotted Bow. Then her eyes went wide as he calmly trotted over to the trail and stopped. Bow came out from the trees, looking at Adora and shrugging as Swift Wind went up to him and nudged at him. Bow began to carefully pet Swift Wind's nose while making little

calming noises at him. Adora started to make her way over and Swift Wind gave her a look but finally let her approach.

"I have never seen him this mellow around someone new," Adora said as she got the lead attached. She had no illusions that it was over, knowing Swift Wind regarded a lead as a suggestion at best, but she had hope at least. "Do you handle horses at your camp?"

"I'm the archery counselor actually," Bow said before turning to Swift Wind. "Well, do you want to get back to the corral?"

Adora swore the horse nodded at him. Bow nodded back. Adora took the lead attached to Swift Wind as Bow turned and started walking down the path when Adora noticed something.

"Bow! Are you OK!? You've got blood on your shorts!" Adora said.

Bow looked over his shoulder at Adora, confused for a moment before reaching around behind himself and feeling the seat of his pants. Then he rolled his eyes in exasperation as he said, "Well that explains the pimples the other day."

Then he froze as he saw Adora's face going through what looked like twenty emotions all at once.

"Bow… are you a woman!?" Adora said in a voice barely above a whisper.

“No, I’m not,” Bow said, his voice flat and level. “I also suggest that you please pick your next words very carefully.”

“But… uh, you’re having… well, you’re…,” Adora started to say and then shut her mouth as she tried to think.

Bow sighed as Swift Wind seemed to give him a look and then nudged Adora with his nose. Bow leaned back against a tree and took a few deep breaths.

“Adora, I’m the same person I was ten minutes ago when we were looking for your horse,” Bow replied. “If knowing that I’m trans changes your opinion of me, that’s your problem, not mine.”

“I don’t get it,” Adora said, her voice timid and quiet.

Bow shook his head as he gave a little chuckle.

“Story of my life,” Bow said. “My dad, George, was a bit confused as well but took it in stride.”

“What did your mom say?” Adora said, knowing exactly what her mom would say.

Bow's face went still and then he gave a tight smile as he said, "I don't know. I never met her." Adora was about to say she was sorry for his loss when he went on. "I'm adopted. My other dad, Lance, had no issues catching on."

If Adora's mind could be represented by a visual at that point it would be a train running off the tracks and rolling across the landscape as it shed parts while loud noises occurred.

"Adora? You there?" Bow said after a short pause as he waved a hand at her. "Is this a problem?"

Finally, Adora's mind managed to reboot and she shook her head as she said, "No, it's OK." Bow began to smile and then Adora went on. "I know how people think Christians react to this kind of thing but the Bible teaches us to love the sinner even while we hate the sin."

Bow's smile died as he said, "I am not a sin or a sinner. If you hate my so-called sin then you're hating the core of who I am as a person and you hate me."

"It's not…," Adora started to say and Bow held his hand up.

"No. I think we should stop. This isn't going to go anywhere productive," Bow said. "Let's just get back to our campsites."

Adora nodded and was about to start walking when she thought of something. She reached into the lower pocket of her cargo shorts and pulled out a pad and held it silently out to Bow. Bow looked down at it and then up at her.

"I, uh, don't know if this will work for… you know," Adora said, not meeting Bow's eyes. "But if you need it…"

Bow gave a tired smile as he reached out and took the pad from her.

"It's not some mysterious thing, Adora. It doesn't need special products," Bow said. "Thank you though."

He disappeared into the trees for a few minutes and came back stuffing the wrapper into his pocket.

"Let's get going," Bow said and headed back down the trail.

The walk back was in silence. Adora's mind was racing but not going anywhere at the same time. She kept thinking of everything she'd ever been taught, that people like Bow were selfish and immoral, and she was trying to weigh it against the evidence she'd seen tonight of Bow walking out into the woods with her late at night to help her find her horse even though it wasn't any concern of his. She kept thinking of the story of the Good Samaritan, who'd stopped in bandit haunted countryside to help a man who'd been attacked, even though that man wasn't of his

religion and it was actually more difficult, and dangerous, to help than to just keep going. She'd been raised her whole life with that story as an example of how to be a good Christian and now here Bow was, showing that kind of compassion, and she wasn't sure what to think because she'd also been taught that the kind of person that Bow was, and the people he hung around and was apparently raised by, didn't care about anyone but themselves.

As they got close to the Bright Moon campsite, she saw Glimmer coming through the trees towards them. Bow blinked his light at her and Adora heard her say, "I can see you just fine, Bow."

"Hello to you as well," Bow said with a laugh.

Glimmer came up to him and gave him a hug before turning to look at Adora.

"Found the horse I see," she said, looking at Adora.

"We did," Bow said as he put an arm around Glimmer.

"Thank you," Adora said and then with much more hesitation continued. "And, uh, I'm sorry about the thing earlier, Bow. I don't hate you."

Before Bow could say anything Glimmer stepped in front of him and glared at Adora as she said, "Why are you saying you don't

hate him? What weird ass thing did you try and do to him?"

"Glimmer, she just figured out I was trans," Bow said with a comforting hand on her shoulder. "It was a bit awkward for all involved but it's alright."

Glimmer looked at Bow before she turned back to Adora.

"Well, you got the horse now. How about you head on back to your camp?" Glimmer said.

"OK," Adora said. She was about to say she'd keep them both in her prayers but decided it might not be a good decision to voice that. "Thank you again."

Bow waved at Adora as she walked back up the trail. When she was out of sight, Glimmer turned to Bow with a worried look on her face.

"Are you sure you're alright? Do you want to go back to camp tonight? We can come back for the boats with Tossa and Spinne tomorrow," Glimmer replied.

Bow kissed her forehead, which annoyed her a little but he liked the little face she made as she spent a moment scrubbing at her forehead, as he said, "It's fine, really. She was just really, really confused. I feel bad for her. I feel like she wants to be a good

person but doesn’t really know how if the other person isn’t part of her thing.”

“Well, I don’t trust those people not to try and, I don’t know, come through screaming scripture and flinging holy water around or something,” Glimmer replied.

“I don’t think their brand of Christian goes in for holy water,” Bow said with a grin.

“Doesn’t matter,” Glimmer said as they began to walk back to their camp. “They’d make it up or use rocks or something.”

As they walked into their campsite and Bow noticed the campfire was still smoldering in the circle of tents.

“Do I need to put that out?” Bow said. “You know you’re not supposed to leave them burning.”

“Yes, *Mother* , I know,” Glimmer said with an eye roll. “I haven’t left it unattended. I’ve been waiting for you to get back. I’ll put it out in just a second.”

“OK,” Bow said and gathered her up in his arms and marveled at how his heart still jumped every time he did. “I’m going to go on and bunk down in the Purple Elephant now.”

“You don’t have to sleep in the bus tonight,” Glimmer whispered.

Bow whispered back, “Yes, I do because I promised your Mom and Dad we wouldn’t bunk up around the campers. That means you don’t come and sleep on the bus with me either.”

She gave him a playful shove as she said, “Fine. Be that way. Figures my boyfriend would be a nerd and follow the rules.”

“You love me anyway though,” Bow said with a smile.

“I do,” Glimmer said back, her face soft and happy. They kissed and then both jumped at a chorus of eleven and twelve year old girls who’d been stealthily watching from the tents suddenly going, “OOOOOOOOOOOO!”

“Alright!” Glimmer laughed as Bow’s face got hot. “Show’s over! Go on back to bed!”

The girls all giggled and Bow gave her one last kiss.

“See you in the morning,” he said as he went toward the bus.

“See you. And I love you!” Glimmer said.

“Love you too,” Bow said back.

Chapter End Notes

I love some good wholesome Glimbow. Also, I love that even Swift Wind was giving Adora the side eye here.

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Catra and Lynda have a conversation.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Adora left, Catra made her way back to the tarps, shaking Kyle and Rogelio's tent as she went past to get their attention and told them Adora had left to look for Swift Wind. Lynda was standing by the tarps when Catra got up to it. The girls had quieted down, most starting to go to sleep or at least chattering quietly with thin sheets over them as they lay on their sleeping bags. Catra could see Bethany laying down near Nicoletta, although Nicoletta was sitting up and glaring at Kaitlyn and her little group but no one was yelling so Catra let it go.

“Swiftie got out?” Lynda said quietly.

“Yeah,” Catra said, nodding at Adora’s headlamp disappearing into the trees. “She’s going to see if she can find him real quick.”

“Can I talk to you for a moment?” Lynda said, very quietly.

Catra looked at her in the gloom and just shrugged and said yes. The two made their way away from the tarp and over to the

corral. After a minute of Lynda looking around to make sure no one was around, she leaned in close to Catra.

"You know about my, you know, tattoo," Lynda said.

"We can talk about that now?" Catra said in a teasing tone of voice.

"Stop it, this is serious," Lynda said.

"OK, yeah, yes, what about it?" Catra responded.

"Can I trust you with another secret?" Lynda said.

Catra's forehead wrinkled a little as she said, "Sure. What's going on?"

"You know how I told you my mom had to move out and she's living with her friend?" Lynda said.

"Yeah, you just said it was something to do with your granddad," Catra said.

“Yeah, it was but that person, she’s not her friend,” Lynda said after a long moment of silence.

“I know, Lynda, I’m not an idiot,” Catra said quietly. “I assume you’re trying to say the friend is her girlfriend or whatever.”

Lynda looked around again before leaning in even closer to Catra.

“So, yeah, Mom is a lesbian and uh, I’m…,” Lynda started and then took a deep shuddering breath before going on. “I’m the same way.”

“What do you mean… *oh,”* Catra replied. The silence piled up between them before Lynda finally spoke up.

“Don’t just sit there staring at me,” Lynda said, low and urgent. “ *Say something.”*

Catra shook herself before saying, “You caught me by surprise. You’re gay?”

Lynda nodded her head and Catra said, “I don’t know what to say. Shit, you’re in the wrong place.”

Lynda let out a sputtering laugh before getting herself under control.

"You think I don't know that?" she said. "I just had to tell someone though and I thought, well…"

She trailed off and looked at Catra expectantly. Catra looked at her and waited for the rest that didn't come before she said, "You thought what?"

"Uh, that… hell, I don't know. I just thought maybe you…," Lynda started to say before she cut off and clamped her mouth shut.

"You think I am as well, don't you?" Catra said and Lynda slowly nodded her head, her eyes scared.

Catra stood there. Admitting something like that was a quick way to get kicked out of her foster family's home at the very least. She had always held the truth of herself close to her heart, hiding her light under a bush, and to see Lynda standing there, terrified, soul bare before her, she couldn't just keep it in.

"I am," Catra said, looking down. She felt tears prick her eyes as she said the thing she'd never admitted before, holding herself tight as she said it.

"Can I hug you?" Lynda asked and Catra looked up and nodded.

The hug was good. It wasn't like hugging Adora, it didn't make Catra's heart leap, but it felt good still. The two stood there, sniffling, for a moment before Lynda finally stepped back.

"I should probably say that I kind of have a thing for you," Lynda muttered. Catra's head went back a little in surprise. "You don't feel the same way do you?"

"I… I don't know," Catra replied.

"You do for Adora though, don't you?" Lynda said.

Catra opened her mouth and then shut it. She couldn't even voice the thought.

"I'm not an idiot," Lynda said. "Watching you around her is why I thought I could tell you about me. Do you two… are you… does she know?"

"No," Catra said, as she looked away.

"You heard what she said tonight," Lynda said. "I think she means it."

If it had happened at the beginning of the week, Catra would have agreed with Lynda and things might have gone differently. However, Catra could still almost hear the litany from Adora's lips the night before, "Let this be, oh Lord God, let this be" and so couldn't just agree to what Lynda was saying.

"I don't know," Catra said. "Maybe she thinks she means it but…"

"What?" Lynda said.

Catra shrugged.

"Nothing, it's just a feeling."

Lynda shuffled her feet for a moment before saying, "It's because you want it to be, because you have a thing for her."

Catra's anger started rising as she said, "It's because of what I see and how she acts."

"You mean when she's telling those kids that there's no homosexuals around?" Lynda said, her voice low and angry now. "Or is it when she sings militant marching songs about Christian soldiers marching to war?"

Catra wanted to say that no, that was the camouflage that Adora put up, but sometimes it slipped when she looked at Catra in an unguarded moment or when she was kneeling over her desperately praying to God for something she couldn't say out loud. However, even as Catra thought about that, it started to seem like delusion. Catra had certainly looked like she was praying fervently enough before and while she still thought what had happened the night before was different, maybe it was just different in her head because she hoped it was so.

"I don't know," Catra said, feeling deflated and tired. "I just…"

"You just hoped. You had faith," Lynda said, sounding just as tired now as Catra felt.

Catra leaned back against a corral post as she said, "Yeah, faith. Mustard seeds and mountains and all that but I guess I don't have enough to move even one person for me."

A little puff of wind moved the thick air and the trees creaked a little as neither one moved. For a moment, the air was a little cooler and then the breeze died out and the heavy mugginess descended again.

"Do you like me just because I'm the only one?" Catra asked finally.

Lynda shook her head as she said, "I don't think so. I've always thought you were funny. I like your smile and your hair… and I just… I figured I could at least ask." She was quiet for a moment before she hung her head and quietly spoke. "We could be happy together, you know. We're out at the barn by ourselves a lot, we could just make a little world for ourselves there, you and I."

Catra looked at her and she could see the dream in her head. Then it died and she could see what it would actually be, hiding, scared at every noise, wondering if anyone knew, and always with the constant anxiety and fear of being discovered and outed. Then she felt tears form in her eyes as she realized that even if Adora wasn't straight like Catra hoped, it would be even worse with her. They would never have anything truly worthwhile at the camp and life would pull them apart when they left at the end of the summer. It was all a beautiful dream and it was only that, a dream that would never be.

Catra tilted her head back to keep the tears from falling as she said, "We can't be happy. It's not allowed."

Catra's eyes went wide as she felt Lynda's hand touch the side of her face.

"Even if the happiness is just for a second, it's still worth it," Lynda said, her words soft and gentle.

Catra reached up and gently touched Lynda's hand. For a moment she could see herself leaning forward, kissing her, holding her, and letting herself have the things she thought about only in her most

private moments. She moved her head and she could barely see Lynda's face in the darkness. Her hand shook slightly as she started to lean forward. Then she screwed her eyes closed and carefully brought Lynda's hand down.

"I can't," Catra whispered. "It's not fair to you. It's not fair to me. It wouldn't ever be able to go anywhere."

"You're hung up on Adora," Lynda said, her voice exhausted.

"No," Catra lied before continuing on and saying something true. "I just know how it'll play out. A moment of happiness might be worth it but more than likely it would just ruin us both."

Lynda reached forward with her other hand and carefully ran it over the back of Catra's hand. Catra gave a tired sigh as she went on.

"You know it's true."

Lynda nodded as she sniffled a little and said, "I guess I do."

"I still like you," Catra said.

Lynda let go of Catra's hand as she said, "That's what hurts the most. I gotta… I gotta just go somewhere for a minute. I'll be back later."

Catra watched her go towards the parking lot and thought about chasing her down but instead she just sat down on the ground, not caring that she was getting soaked, and put her head on her knees.

Chapter End Notes

I should say I wrote most of this chapter to This Night by Black Lab. Which explains so much honestly.

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Back to camp we go, each with their thoughts, and each not knowing what's to come.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

Note: I've updated the tags to reflect this but there is some homophobic language (and internalized homophobia) in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The horses came up over the last rise in the trail and they moved along the fence towards the barn. Adora wasn't sure what was going on but neither Catra or Lynda had said much the whole morning on the way back. The girls had been pretty quiet as well but Adora figured that had a lot to do with not getting much sleep in what had felt like a steam bath part of the night. Adora did like that Nicoletta was sticking around Bethany now and they seemed to have picked up another friend, Victoria, who was a bit shy and low on cabin popularity as well. Adora just hoped there'd be less drama going forward now.

The night before she'd got back to the corral and let Swift Wind in. He'd been docile all the way back and gave a little shake of his coat as he'd looked around the corral. Adora kept an eye on him for a moment before looking around for Catra. She saw her sitting on the other side of the corral and she made her way over to her to find her asleep leaned against the post.

“Catra?” Adora said as she gently put a hand on her shoulder. Catra’s eyes opened and then squinted at the light from Adora’s headlamp.

“Sorry,” Adora said as she shut it off. “What are you doing sleeping out here?”

“Nothing,” Catra said and Adora’s eyes opened a little at the brusque way Catra spoke. “Just sat down waiting for you and I guess I fell asleep.”

“Well, I’m back,” Adora said. “I’m going to the bathroom and then going to bed.”

“Sure, see you in the morning,” Catra said as she got to her feet and went towards the tarps.

Adora stood up and watched her go, surprised that Catra hadn’t stuck around.

She must be really tired, Adora thought as she made her way to the bathroom.

The next morning wasn’t any better. The only people who seemed remotely cheerful had been Kyle and Rogelio who’d been up before anyone and began to get everything packed away after handing out single serving cereal boxes and small bottles of milk.

Rogelio was whistling as he began to move things to the van and Kyle was bouncing along hauling the few bags of trash they had to the dumpster. Lynda didn't seem to really look at anyone as she went and started checking each horse to make sure they were alright. Adora tried to strike up a conversation with her but it hadn't gone very far. Catra had been almost silent, only answering direct questions, and Adora finally just concentrated on getting everything ready to go.

She kept looking towards Bright Moon's camp though as she replayed the events of the previous night over and over. At one point she was waiting by the bathroom for Melanie, Kaitlyn's friend, and she could just see them back in the trees, moving around as they broke down their camp, and she saw Bow getting stuff into the back of their bus. He looked up and saw her watching and gave a wave to her. She returned it and then faltered a little as Glimmer came up behind him. Adora was waiting for the inevitable glare, or even obscene hand gesture, and was surprised when Glimmer just gave her a little nod before saying something to Bow and going back to rounding up her campers.

"Why are you waving at them?" Melanie said as she came out of the bathroom.

"Because it's the friendly thing to do," Adora replied.

"But they're, you know, like witches or something," Melanie said.

Adora looked at her in confusion as she said, “What are you talking about?”

Melanie looked at Adora like she was so out of the loop as she said, “I heard their camp owner is like a witch or sorcerer or something and he has a big ceremony every month over there. That’s why it’s called Bright Moon, because they worship the moon.”

Adora tried to think of what to say before she finally just said, “Even if that’s true, they’re still children of God and we’re supposed to love them. They’re our neighbors after all and Jesus was very clear on that.”

Melanie rolled her eyes as she said, “I know, Mark 12.”

Adora was about to say to go ahead and wave back to Melanie but Bow had already gone back to getting ready to go and Kaitlyn was calling for Melanie. Melanie went trotting off towards Kaitlyn and the couple of girls around her and Adora just sighed and followed along. When she got back, Lynda and Catra were already helping the girls get horses saddled and Kyle and Rogelio were leaning against the van, ready to leave. Adora got Swift Wind saddled and once everything was packed away, they did a walk through their campsite to be sure nothing had been left behind, trash or otherwise.

After that was done, Adora got everyone to stand in front of her and began the little church service. She had originally planned to give the Talk at this point but as she started, she just couldn’t find

it in herself to handle something so heavy. She looked at the little notebook she had in her hand with the bullet points she had to cover for it and finally just snapped it closed and decided to wing the service. She led them in singing a couple of worship songs and ended that with Amazing Grace and felt herself perk up a bit as they sang. Then she began to speak.

"I love that song. Catra knows it's my favorite song and it's my favorite for a reason. Romans 3:23 says that all have sinned and fallen short of the glory of God. It's a verse much quoted and with good reason but something that doesn't get quoted nearly enough is the next verse. Verse 24 says 'and are justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus' and that's important. We all mess up. We all make mistakes with those around us, we don't do what we should, and we don't speak up like we ought to but grace is ours anyway. We can be redeemed. We can do the right thing, even though we've fallen short. Let's pray."

Adora led them in a short prayer and then called it done. Kyle and Rogelio waved good-bye and got into the van. Adora watched as Glimmer and her girls trooped back towards the river, Glimmer giving her an odd look before turning away. Adora got up on Swift Wind as she heard the Bright Moon bus start up at the same time as the van and turned to see Bow leaning out the window of the bus, waving at the van with its trailer to go ahead of him. Rogelio leaned out of the window of the van and gave him a thumbs up and Adora leaned into the saddle as she tried to figure out what she was feeling.

"We going?" Lynda said.

“Yeah, sorry,” Adora said with a smile. “We’re going. Want to lead off?”

Lynda didn’t reply but just nudged her horse up to a trot and went forward. Catra went right after her and Adora frowned as she took up the rear of the line of horses heading out. They didn’t stop for a break and just pressed on and so they were back at the barn by late morning. The clouds had cleared pretty quickly but the humidity had stuck around so most of the ride had been hot and miserable although Adora had to be glad it at least hadn’t been full of dust off the trail.

After getting the tack off the horses, Lynda and Catra started getting them taken care of while the girls formed up outside. Adora stood there for a moment, wondering why everyone was so quiet and why it felt so uncomfortable at the moment, before finally speaking up.

“You want me to run some lunch out for you two or are you going to make it in?” Adora said.

“We’ll figure it out,” Catra said.

“I don’t mind,” Adora replied.

Catra stopped for a moment and looked at her as she said, “It’s fine, Adora.”

“Are you mad at me?” Adora said as she stepped up a little closer and then was surprised to see Catra step back a step.

“No, I’m just really tired, we got a lot of work, and a group is coming around later today to ride. Just head on back,” Catra said and then her face softened a little. “I’ll see you at dinner, OK?”

As Adora walked off with her cabin, Lynda came up to Catra and said, “Why are you being mean to her all of a sudden?”

Catra snapped her head around as she said, “I’m not, I’m just finally being realistic. I’m just a stupid little dyke stuck at this stupid camp and the only thing I’ve got to look forward to is having a crush on a girl who, if she knew the truth, would run screaming for the hills or try and lay hands on me and drive out the demon that made me a lesbo and that’s the best case scenario.”

Lynda looked down at the floor as she held a few halters in her hand. She looked up and for a moment Catra thought she was going to say something. Then Lynda just sighed and walked off.

When Adora and her cabin got back, they found their stuff neatly stacked in the cabin where Kyle and Rogelio had brought it back. They put it away and then ran over to the showers. Afterwards, it was lunch, and then crafts. Adora dove deep into everything, trying to distract herself from what seemed like a rage of thoughts in her head. Shortly before dinner, she let the girls go to have

some free time. They all went to a set of benches in the shade of a big tree and Adora, not really having anywhere to go, found herself sitting on a bench away from the girls but looking out over the river.

She looked at a small sandbar just downstream from them. It'd been getting larger for the last two years and Adora noticed that some willows were growing on it now. She'd been out to it the year before with one of the kayaks the camp had and she remembered walking around on it. Before the rest of the people following along with her in canoes caught up, she felt like she was all alone in a little pocket of space that was out of time and now looking at it, she wondered what it'd be like to sit among the willows, invisible to the world.

Adora turned as motion across the river caught her eye. She couldn't make out facial features at the distance she was but it wasn't hard to notice the height disparities between the two people on the end of the dock. Adora watched as Bow threw his head back and she just knew he was laughing. Glimmer standing next to him gave him a playful push and then the two went back to whatever job they had been doing.

Across the river, Bow was shaking his head as he kept chuckling. He picked up a life jacket as they worked on tidying up the dock as he said, "Well, it's nice you don't think she's a complete monster."

"She thought you needed a special pad for your period, Bow," Glimmer said with a laugh before she glared across the river for a moment. "I still say overall most of them are probably evil but yeah, she's probably not evil. Just really, really confused."

“I feel bad for her,” Bow said. “I don’t know why but she just seemed so, I don’t know, lost. Like you could tell when she was parroting something she had been taught and then there were those moments when you could see a good person peeking out. And yes, the pad thing was one of those moments.”

Glimmer gave him a fake scowl as she said, “Is my boyfriend getting interested in straight girls all of a sudden?”

Bow laughed as he said, “If I was going to be interested in straight girls, I’d be interested in Isla. Funny and makes great pottery.”

Glimmer grinned as she thought of Isla, another cabin counselor, and said, “Bow, she’s not straight.”

“What? Since when?” Bow said.

“Since Mom found her making out with Cariana in the arts and crafts closet the day before we left for the trip,” Glimmer said. “I’m surprised you haven’t seen them running around holding hands.”

Bow threw his head back and laughed again.

Back on the bluff, Adora saw Bow laugh again and sighed as she wondered what he was laughing about. She had hoped Catra would join her at the benches so they could hang out but it didn't look like that was going to happen. When she thought of Catra, she clenched her hands together a little. Thoughts kept bouncing up at her and she kept trying to ignore them. Then she saw Bow and Glimmer hug before walking away hand in hand down the dock and the thought of doing that with Catra came screaming through her mental defenses so fast she had to hang her head so people wouldn't see her face. She thought about the feel of Catra's hand in hers and for a moment her whole body shook before she took a deep breath and finally fought it back down.

"Adora?"

Adora looked up to see Bethany standing there with Victoria and Nicoletta. Adora plastered a fake smile across her face as she said, "What's up?"

"Is it ok if we go back to the cabin for a minute? Victoria wants to change shoes," Bethany asked.

"Sure, thanks for letting me know," Adora said, on autopilot.

Nicoletta frowned as she said, "Well, we ask unlike Melanie and Kaitlyn who just go running off."

Adora looked at Nicoletta as she said, “It’s alright to do that. It’s free time after all.”

Nicoletta was about to say something but Bethany started going as she said, “Come on! Before we’re out of time!” and then three were off, chatting back and forth. Adora looked across at Bright Moon again before sighing and standing up. The wind was starting to die off a little as Adora saw storm clouds starting to gather again and frowned as she wondered if she should go and grab her poncho or if she had time until after dinner.

Chapter End Notes

> For those of you who've read my other stuff, I kept meaning to point out that I've pulled one of my own OC's into this. Nicoletta is based on Izzy from my post-season five canon. Nicoletta is actually her birth name in those fics but she hates it for reasons and goes by Izzy. Will she have a big part in this? Meh, probably not but I needed a quiet character who was absolutely willing to throw down for a friend without hesitation and hey, look at that. Also, I'm sure the gathering storm has absolutely no literary symbolism and is just a thing.

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

It's dinner time at Camp Horde for the Lord as a storm approaches.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dinner that night felt weird for Adora. Melanie and Kaitlyn had been running behind, barely showing up just in time to go in and sit down with the cabin. Then Catra had been late and had slid onto the bench across from her right after the prayer for the meal had ended and right before everyone started getting up to get in line. Adora tried to get her to chat but Catra had just muttered at her a little, not really engaging with her and Adora made a note to ask her what was going on after dinner.

Halfway through dinner, a woman that worked in the kitchen had come up and told Catra there was an issue out at the barn and she was needed. Catra muttered at Adora she'd see her at the church service that evening and gathered up her tray.

"Catra, are you alright? You've been kind of down today," Adora said.

Catra looked at her and for a moment Adora saw anger on her face before it went away as she said, "I'm just tired. I didn't sleep

well, I worked all day in that stifling barn, and now I have to run back. I'll see you later."

Adora was about to say maybe she should have Lynda go with her to make it quicker when she looked around and realized that Lynda wasn't in the dining hall. Catra took advantage of her looking away and walked off. Adora watched her go before looking down at her food, a preformed hamburger patty covered in brown gravy and reconstituted mushrooms sitting on top of lumpy mashed potatoes. A green salad of iceberg lettuce and a few sad carrot flakes awash in cheap Italian dressing sat in the little salad portion of her dinner tray next to another compartment of creamed corn. She'd been eating away just fine up to that moment but now she felt like she couldn't have another bite as she pushed her tray away a little.

Melanie stopped talking to Kaitlyn and gave Adora a smile, one that felt vaguely hostile for some reason coming from a twelve year old, as she said, "Are you done?"

"I think I am," Adora said.

"I'll take that for you then," Melanie said as she stood up. She took a few more trays and walked them over to the dish pit before coming back and talking. Not too long after, the evening announcements began and again, Adora felt off balance. They were always given by Joshua but this time it was given by Octavia. Adora wondered if maybe Joshua was going to be in a skit that they sometimes did at dinner but Adora looked around and couldn't see him.

“A reminder if you want to be baptized, either for the first time or as a re-dedication, we’ll be doing that this Sunday evening,” Octavia said as she read off the paper in her hand. “Tell your counselor or sign up on the sheet outside Prime’s office. Also, tonight's game of Capture the Flag is going to be canceled because of the expected rain. We’ll gather here after chapel and do a Bible quiz instead.”

Adora couldn’t shake the feeling of strangeness. Even the chance at a Bible quiz didn’t drive it from her head. A few people did a skit on stage, something about a chair with a do not sit sign on it and Adora vaguely was aware it had something to do with sin and disregarding instructions but she wasn’t really paying attention. It was followed by one of the band members playing the guitar while someone sang and someone else did an interpretive dance to the worship song. Adora couldn’t focus and the fact that the after dinner events just seemed to keep going for what felt longer than normal was throwing her off. She was deep in thought when a hand touched her on the shoulder and the surprise of it caused her to jump. She looked up to see the same woman who’d come and got Catra.

“What’s up?” Adora said.

“Leslie,” the woman said, referring to another cabin counselor, “is having an issue. Could you go and meet her outside really quick? I’ll stay with your cabin.”

“You don’t have to,” Adora said as she smiled at her girls. “I know they can behave themselves for a few minutes while I’m gone.”

The girls, who'd all turned to see what was going on, smiled back at her. However, again, Adora felt a little weird out at how Melanie was looking at her and she noticed that Kaitlyn and another girl that hung around with her were looking at her oddly as well. Adora just shook it off as nothing as she stood up.

"Back in a few," Adora said as she grabbed her clipboard and went outside. As she went out, she looked around trying to spot Leslie. Then she heard Joshua's smooth voice.

"Adora, if you could come over here for a moment?"

Adora turned to see him standing over by a fence that screened the dumpsters from the patio in front of the dining hall. The light was dim as clouds had moved over the sun while she'd been inside. She walked on over to him as her back involuntarily straightened up a little.

"Hello, sir, I'm looking for Leslie. I heard she needed me for something," Adora said.

"Leslie is off handling something for me right now," Joshua replied with a smile. "I sent for you. Please, come to my office."

Adora would normally have just followed along but something in her had her pause as she said, "Why? Is something wrong, sir?"

Joshua looked at her with a raised eyebrow as the smile slid from his face. He said, “We’ll see. Now, please, my office.”

Adora felt herself pull back a little as she suddenly remembered she needed to be submissive before authority as she’d been taught but that didn’t stop her mind from running as she followed Joshua over to his office. He went inside and sat down at his desk. Adora noticed several folders laid out on the desk, one green and the other two red. Joshua opened one of the red ones and Adora saw a picture of Lynda in it as well as a sheet of paper that Adora recognized as a sheet of information about a camper. It was usually filled out by parents and had things like emergency contact information, the person’s birthday, health histories, and the like. Adora had seen one every year she’d been and had filled her own out the last few years at her mother’s insistence. At the top of the paper, in a space Adora had only seen blank except for the words, “For Official Camp Use - Do Not Write In”, was a stamp that said, “Scholarship - Class D.”

Joshua opened another folder and Adora saw this one was Catra’s folder. It had a scholarship designation on the camper packet but her paper was stamped, “Scholarship - Class B.” Adora then noticed behind each was a sheet of red paper. She saw that Joshua was looking at her and she quickly looked away from the folders. Her heart was pounding as he picked up Adora’s folder and just held it for a moment as he looked at her.

“Do you have any idea why you’re standing here right now?” Joshua said carefully.

“No, sir,” Adora said.

“None at all?” he said. “Anything you say is helpful in this matter. I simply wish to get to the bottom of everything.”

“Sir, I really don’t know why you have me in here,” Adora said.

Joshua stared at her before giving her a smile with no kindness in it as he said, “You may sit down. You don’t have to remain standing.”

Adora quickly sat down in the chair facing his desk as he opened her folder and lay it on the desk. Adora noticed that her folder did not have a red sheet of paper inside of it and wasn’t stamped scholarship. Josh flipped through the sheets for a moment, not saying anything, before he let the paper go. As it dropped into place, he looked at her with a serious face as he said, “Well, Adora, you have an excellent record here. A good camper who loves the Lord and strives always to serve and to honor those who have been put into authority over you as well as being a good example to those who are under you.”

He paused and looked at her, as if expecting her to say something.

“Thank you, sir, I do try to do so,” she said.

He nodded, as if that was the right thing to say.

“I know you do,” Joshua said. “Which is why I am so shocked at reports I’m hearing from your overnight trip. Is there anything you want to tell me about?”

Adora was now just confused as she said, “Sir, I’m not sure. A couple of the girls had an argument and I mediated it. Then Swift Wind got out of the corral and I had to go chase him down. When I got back, I put him in the corral and went to bed. Then we came back this morning.”

Joshua nodded, his face calm as if nothing she was telling him was new. When she finished he said, “I understand Camp Bright Moon was camped nearby.”

Adora nodded as she said, “Yes, sir. I said hello when they first arrived and then ran into the two counselors in charge when I was looking for Swift Wind. One of them helped me out looking for him.”

“Why didn’t you tell me that a minute ago?”

“Because I didn’t think of it, sir,” Adora lied. She had but she had justified it with telling herself it wasn’t important.

“Who helped you?” Joshua said and Adora suddenly thought she knew what this was all about even though she had no idea how

Joshua would know.

"His name was Bow, sir," Adora said. "I know he's a boy but I wasn't thinking and he was polite. He didn't do anything."

"Was the other counselor a shorter woman? Purple hair?" Joshua said.

"Yes, sir," Adora said and for the life of her couldn't figure out why she felt bad for revealing that.

"Adora, that woman is the owner's daughter. That person who she was with isn't a man, she's a very sick and confused woman," Joshua said. Adora tried to hide her irritated reaction at Joshua as she thought of Bow and how helpful and kind he'd been but she wasn't successful. However, Joshua just took her reaction for revulsion and nodded. "That's right. You're eighteen but you've been raised in a loving, Christian home so you probably have only passingly heard of such things. Yes, I'd be upset with you for that but it would be more along the lines of cautioning you to be more careful in the future. That's not the issue however."

"I don't understand. What is the issue?" Adora said, not even realizing she'd left off the sir but Joshua didn't seem to notice as he pulled Catra's folder to him again, flicked back the top sheet and looked at the red paper under it. Then he did the same with Lynda's and looked at it for a moment. Finally he looked back at her.

"You're very close with Catrina I've noticed," Joshua said. It took Adora a second to recognize Catra's actual name but she finally just nodded. "Do you have any reason to believe she's a deviant?"

"I'm sorry, sir, I don't know what you mean," Adora said.

"A homosexual, Adora," Joshua replied. "Do you have any reason to believe that? I want the truth from you. Trying to protect her is misguided. You're only hurting her, and yourself, if you don't tell me."

"Sir, no, I have no reason to believe that," Adora said.

Joshua nodded as he said, "I have a report that she and Lynda were by the corral last night while you were gone. It's not a clear report but it seems that at least Lynda may have tried to do something perverted. Catrina though, it's unclear what she was doing."

Adora gripped the sides of her clipboard so tight it creaked. The first thought she had was an irritated, *Why would Catra do that with her?* that she then immediately shook loose and started to shove down. Then the fear of what Joshua was saying sunk in and the thought disappeared as she realized what this meant.

"Sir, that doesn't seem right," Adora said.

"You're correct, it's not right. Homosexuality never is," Joshua said. "It doesn't matter. I reviewed both of their discipline records. Nothing major except, well, Lynda has a tattoo. I was going to overlook it. Her grandfather is a large contributor to this camp and a Godly man. When I found out about it last year, I spoke with him. He asked if I could ignore it and I said I would if she was discreet. When I found out about this however, I contacted him. He said she wasn't welcome in his home any longer and that I should do whatever God led me to do. After much prayer, God has led me to the answer. I'm dismissing her."

Adora just sat there, not sure what to say. She sat her clipboard down and leaned over, her hands clutched in front of her, as she kept thinking of how she'd been taught that kindness and forgiveness were the cornerstone of Christianity. That mercy and grace were extended even to those who didn't deserve it, in fact especially to those who didn't deserve it. She just kept wondering what was the point of dismissing her? Why not try and save her, talk with her, and help her?

"You're shocked, I understand," Joshua said. "Catrina denied any of this when I spoke to her at first. Understandable, her foster parents say she's a willful child who can be disobedient over just about anything. However, she finally caved. Wouldn't tell me much though, just that she had told Lynda she felt weird sometimes and was having impure thoughts and Lynda had done nothing. I understand. She's probably trying to protect Lynda. No matter. She at least had repentance in her heart for her sickness. I prayed over her and asked God to heal her diseased mind. She wept. She admitted things that I won't tell you about but she asked to be baptized and re-dedicate herself so I sent her to the pool to have it done immediately. Do you know why I'm telling you this, Adora?"

Adora almost didn't answer as the words from Joshua's mouth drove away the thoughts of what was being done to Lynda. The thought of Catra weeping broke her heart but she finally managed to shake her head as she said, "No, sir. I don't."

"I'm going to keep her on here," Joshua said and Adora's heart leapt for a moment. "However, because of her illness, I will not have her interacting with the campers. That means, because of your position, you will not interact with her either. You must be above reproach. If you had been in the campsite when this happened last night, I would more than likely be taking you out of your position right now as well and putting you in a similar position as she'll be in. I'm not entering this on your record to spare you but I'll remember. Be the good Christian girl I know you to be and you won't have any problems."

Adora knew that was a threat. She'd wanted to be a head cabin counselor for years and had worked hard for it. Before, it would have been an effective threat but now, she just didn't care as she thought of Catra but she needed to answer.

"I understand, sir. Thank you for trusting me," Adora said as she put on the fake smile she used when her mother told her to stop being so sad. "I'll do what's right."

"I know you will, Adora," Joshua said. "Because I don't miss anything."

# # #

Elsewhere, Lynda walked down a dirt road, a footlocker up on her shoulder. She'd been coming to dinner, running really late after making sure things were solid at the barn, when she'd stopped in the trees. She'd watched in the gloom of the gathering clouds as Catra had walked out of Joshua's office in a white baptismal robe with several counselors around her. Her hair was tied back and Lynda watched as one of the counselors threw the cat ear headband into the garbage can outside the office. They went on, one of them carrying a Bible, towards the pool.

Lynda was pretty sure she knew what had probably happened. She figured Catra had probably felt guilty and gone to Joshua to confess. Because of that, she was being given a chance. Lynda had no illusions of what would probably happen to her and she wasn't really interested in finding out if she was right or not. She didn't hesitate. She turned around and made her way back to the cabin she shared with some of the other activities counselors.

She cleared the few things off her shelves, threw them in the camp provided footlocker with the rest of her stuff, made sure the stuffed scorpion toy she had was safely tucked in there, and then shut it and hefted it to her shoulder. It was technically camp property but she didn't want to take time to get everything out and packed. Besides, what did she care if she stole from those who hated her? She was damned if she was going to be escorted out and she had a feeling Joshua would make a production of it to shame her and make an example. Besides, she'd always had an idea of what she would do if things ever went bad.

The footlocker was heavy but not as heavy as the bales of hay that she hauled off of Tara's truck. Now, going up the dirt road,

she went towards where those bales of hay came from. She stopped outside an open wrought iron gate, the brand to Crimson Waste Farms expertly worked into it, and looked around. Contrary to its name, the farm looked quite beautiful even in the dim light right before the storm she knew was about to fall. There was an old white two story farmhouse that had been lovingly maintained with a beautiful blue door and a rainbow flag flying on the porch. Behind the house was a large tin barn. Lynda saw a woman come out on the porch, someone she didn't recognize, and look at her. Then she turned around and said something back into the house that Lynda couldn't make out before turning around and gesturing at Lynda to come on up. Lynda walked up as Tara came out on the porch and looked at her as she sat the footlocker down.

"You're Lynda, from the camp up the road," Tara said.

"Yeah," Lynda replied.

"Running away from the looks of it," Tara said with a nod at the footlocker.

"I guess but maybe I'm just coming to my senses instead."

"Well, Lynda, can't say I don't understand," Tara said. "Come on in."

Lynda reached down and picked up the footlocker and as she put it back on her shoulder she said, "Can I ask you a favor?"

“What is it?” Tara said.

“Can you call me Scorpia instead?”

Tara grinned as she slapped a hand on her other shoulder.

“Can do, Scorpia.”

Chapter End Notes

I can taste that hamburger patty and I’d be lying if I said I didn’t want it. Is it good? No. Is it nostalgic? Oh yes. Camp food holds a special place in my heart. I even loved those powdered eggs.

Also, I always wondered if Scorpia’s stuffed scorpion from the show went with her to Bright Moon or not and the thought of it getting left behind to probably be destroyed in the Fright Zone bummed me out. Not in this fic. This is my fix-it damn it. Snippy makes it out this time!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Adora has been forbidden from seeing Catra. What is she going to do?

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

Note: for those following along as I post, I posted a chapter before this one today. Make sure you don't miss it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stepped out of the office and as she went down the steps, her eyes caught the edge of Catra's headband in the trash. She turned around to see Joshua on the phone and then stepped to the side where he wouldn't see her before reaching in and pulling the headband out. A few strands of Catra's long hair were still on it and Adora's eyes misted up as she looked at it. Catra wore those things everywhere, like armor, barely ever taking them off. She'd seen Catra swim in them and sleep in them. Now, holding the headband in her hand, Adora had to fight back tears. She heard Joshua get off the phone and Adora quickly put the headband back in the trash and headed back towards the dining hall.

Her cabin was still there, most of the people having cleared out, and Adora forced a smile on her face as she went in. The girls were getting antsy as she said, "Come on, time to head back to the cabin everyone. We've got a full evening ahead of us."

Adora didn’t realize she was speaking in almost a monotone and didn’t see Melanie’s smug smile or Kaitlyn's uncomfortable look at Melanie as Adora got them all rounded up and heading towards the cabin. As they walked towards the cabins, she kept looking around, hoping to see Catra but not even sure what she would do if she saw her. She thought about going for the rest of the summer and not seeing her. She thought of going for the rest of her life and maybe not seeing her and she was shaking a little when she got back to the cabin. The thought of losing her friend screamed in her head as she directed the girls to get their ponchos ready and that they’d be heading out soon.

The wind was starting to really pick up when someone came to the cabin. Adora could see lightning in the distance as a counselor came running up.

“Hey, big storm moving in,” the counselor said. “Make sure you batten down your windows and listen for the tornado siren. Joshua said to have individual services in the cabins tonight unless it lets up in time.”

Adora nodded and reached for her clipboard to make a note and suddenly realized she’d left it in Joshua’s office. As the counselor ran on to give the warning to the next cabin in her little cluster, Adora stood up.

“Girls, I gotta run back to Joshua’s office. I forgot my clipboard,” Adora replied. “Can you manage without me for a little while.” There was a chorus of yeahs and of courses and Adora nodded. “Get the shutters put down over the window and if you hear the tornado siren, head for the bathhouse like we talked about alright? Don’t wait on me.”

The girls got up and went outside to start dropping the heavy wooden shutters over the screen windows as Adora went over to the cabin next to hers. The counselor there was in charge of a group of girls a little younger than Adora's cabin and looked up as Adora knocked on the door and then stuck her head inside.

"Mary, I gotta run off to the main camp for a moment," Adora said. "Can you keep an eye on my kids for a little while? Just poke your head in every once in a while?"

"Sure, I can do that," Mary said. "Get me out the canoe cleaning next weekend?"

Adora quickly nodded as she said, "Sure, that's fine. Thank you."

Adora ran down the trail, half planning to just grab her clipboard and half wanting to see if she could find Catra to make sure she was alright. She was sure that Catra was just covering for Lynda and she wanted to see why Catra would say something about herself like what Joshua had told Adora about. She never got near Joshua's office though. She was moving past the benches when she saw the curtain of rain still several miles off but closing fast across the landscape. Then she saw Catra, by herself, walking down the steep trail that went to the base of the bluff where the camp dock was located.

Adora went after her but Catra was moving faster than Adora expected and so was the rain. As she got to the bottom, the rain

was starting to fall fast and heavy. She could see Catra standing on the edge of the dock, watching the swirling river go past.

"Catra!" Adora shouted as she went out onto the dock.

Catra turned and looked at her, her eyes tired, as she said, "Hello, Adora. You're not supposed to be around me you know and I'm supposed to be called Catrina now. It's my proper name after all."

Adora crossed through a little covered part of the dock to stand not too far from Catra.

"Catra, what's going on? What did you say to Joshua? What's happening?"

"Adora, I'm supposed to report back to him if you try and talk with me," Catra looked at her, water dripping down her forehead as the rain fell around them. "I will too. It's for our own good. Go on and I'll forget about it this one time."

"I'm not leaving until you tell me what you said and why," Adora said. "He just told me you had confessed to something awful."

Catra hung her head and gave a tired laugh.

“Awful? Sure, yeah, I did. Just go away.”

Adora stepped closer as she said, “Catra! Lynda is getting kicked out because apparently she’s a homosexual! You’re supposedly saying the same thing but you get to stay but I can’t see you! What is going on!?”

Catra shook her head as she pushed past Adora, “Again, leave it alone. I won’t tell him you did this but don’t do it again. Just forget about me. It’s like you told me what your mom told you years ago. You shouldn’t do this for someone who doesn’t matter.”

Adora turned as Catra was walking through the sheltered part of the dock and went right after her.

“Don’t you ever say that! You’re my friend! You matter to me!”

Catra stopped as thunder rumbled through the sky before turning around and she felt something crack in her.

“You want to know why I said what I said!? You know why I went and got baptized again!? You know why I’m willing to turn you in!? Because I’m trying to protect you! I’m trying to keep you out of this!” Catra shouted back at her.

“Why!? Catra, that makes no sense! You don’t have to admit to something that’s not true!” Adora said.

Catra looked at her for a moment before she screamed back, “It is true because I love you!”

The rain screamed down as Adora looked at Catra in shock.

“You… you don’t mean… no, you mean love like phileo love, right?” Adora said, her eyes wide.

Catra threw her hands up in the air as Adora used the ancient Greek word for brotherly love.

“No, Adora! I don’t mean that! I mean I love you! Like I want to be with you and hold you and kiss you and… and yes, that!” Catra said as she saw the thought cross Adora’s mind at the same time as it did Catra’s.

“No,” Adora said, shaking her head. “No, that’s not you talking, that’s the Devil. That’s not right. That’s not what God intends! We’re friends!”

Catra felt tears start down her face in anger as she said, “What God intends!? What does He intend!? What about that Psalm you love so much!?” Catra beat her chest with her fist as she went on. “I am beautifully and fearfully made, remember!? God made me this way and if He made me this way and then said it’s a sin to love you like I do, then damn Him!”

“Catra!” Adora shouted. “Take that back right now!”

“NO! I’ve felt this way for years! I’m tired of not being honest about it! If I’m his child and He made me this way and then calls me a sinner for it then damn Him! He’s evil and doesn’t deserve my love!” Catra yelled back at her.

Adora stepped forward, her hand out and for a brief moment Catra had hope as Adora laid her hand on her shoulder. She felt her heart race in happiness that then crumbled a moment later as Adora spoke.

“Let me pray for you…,” Adora started to say.

“Get your damn hand off me!” Catra said as she shoved it away. “Don’t pretend like you don’t feel the same way! I see it in your eyes when you’re not fighting to hide it!”

“Everyone has these temptations,” Adora said. “A good Christian stands up to them!”

“Then I’m not a good Christian!” Catra said. “If being a good Christian means hating people because of how God supposedly made them then I’d rather just be a good person and care about those people!”

Adora stood there, not sure what to say. She looked at Catra, soaked from the rain, face as angry as the thunderstorm that raged around them, and she felt the urge to rush forward and pull her to her and kiss her. She could feel it in her and then she forced the thought down.

"You don't mean that," Adora whispered.

Catra gave a weeping laugh as she said, "I have never meant anything more in my life!"

Adora shook her head as she said, "Catra, I don't know what to say! I care for you too but…"

"Don't. Just don't," Catra said and Adora could see the pain and despair inside of her. "Lynda and I talked about this. I knew it was a delusion that you would love me like I love you but I still did what I did because I do love you and as much as I hate myself for saying it, I'd do it again but please, stop making this harder. If you ever cared about me, just let me go."

Catra started to walk away and Adora was about to step up to her and tell her that she was absolutely not going to do anything of the sort, that she'd go back and stand up to Joshua, that she'd say something that'd change what was going on, and all the while she kept thinking of grabbing Catra and holding her and kissing her and she wasn't sure what was going on and so for a moment she didn't recognize that Catra had slipped on the rain slick boards of the dock. She watched in open mouthed horror as Catra hit the

river in the driving rain. Then she grabbed a life vest and dove in after her.

Chapter End Notes

At least it wasn't a cliff edge this time.

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

> Into the river, swirling around, lost in the storm, where shall this all end?

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?
>
> Note: for those following along while I post, this is the third chapter I've posted today. Please make sure you read the other two first.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Damn it, Frosta,” Glimmer shouted over the rain as she worked the flat bottomed boat downriver. “I can’t believe you did this!”

“Hey!” a twelve year old girl said from the seat of the boat in front of Glimmer. Her name was Caroline but she’d insisted on being called Frosta a few years back when she first came to camp and it’d stuck. “I didn’t sink the boat on purpose!”

“You didn’t even have permission to be out on the river today and certainly not by yourself!” Glimmer shot back as she finally caught sight of the Bright Moon docks. “You know it’s starting to get up to flood stage! It’s posted right on the dock!”

“But it’s not *at* flood stage *yet,”* Frosta shot back.

Bow just kept watch forward, not wanting to get between the two. Frosta had always followed Glimmer around and after a little misunderstanding the year before, the two had got close. However, it was close like sisters and so the two were constantly snipping at each other.

"Bow, back me up here!" Glimmer said and Bow just shook his head.

"Nope, not getting involved," Bow said and then they all flinched at the sound of thunder. Then, in the dim light of the storm, he thought he spotted something orange down river. He sat up a little bit more to try and get a better look.

"Bow, as my boyfriend…," Glimmer started to say when Bow waved back at her to cut her off without taking his eyes off where he was looking.

"Do you two see that?" he said, pointing at it. "Looks like a life jacket."

Glimmer and Frosta squinted a little as they looked and suddenly Frosta said, "Someone's clinging to it!"

Glimmer opened up the throttle on the outboard motor and shot them forward.

“Watch out for sandbars!” Bow shouted as he moved forward a little to keep the front of the boat on the water as they rocketed forward.

“The river is flooding, Bow! There’s no sandbars right now!” Glimmer shouted back.

“You mean that one!” Frosta yelled, pointing at the big sandbar mid-river with the willows growing out of it.

The boat darted sideways as Glimmer said, “Doesn’t count!”

Meanwhile, in the water Adora had managed to catch up with Catra but the river below the docks went deep as it went along more bluffs. She’d tried to swim for the sandbar but had missed it. Catra was yelling at her to just let go but Adora just held onto her. She was already tired, the water was swift, and she was terrified of the bridge she knew wasn’t too far down river. She’d seen the wood piled up against its pilings from prior floods and she knew what would happen if she couldn’t swim clear of it. Then she heard something amazing. She heard an outboard motor close by.

Getting onboard was difficult and having five people on board was pretty close to the boat's weight limit even on the best of days, much less on a storm tossed river, but they managed. They got sorted out, Adora holding Catra close as they sat down on the mid-bench. Frosta sat at the front of the boat like a figurehead as Glimmer turned back into the flow of the river and shoved the throttle all the way over to full and began to fight back upstream against the current.

“Adora!?” Bow said as he recognized her and it was in that instant that Adora realized who had rescued them.

“Hey, Bow,” Adora said. “This is Catra.”

When they finally made it to the Bright Moon dock, Adora saw a tall woman waiting under the covered dock portion with a worried look. Standing next to her was a shorter man who was just shaking his head as Glimmer made it in and got everything tied off. Right before Glimmer shut the engine down, it sputtered and died with a little cloud of smoke coming out from under the engine shroud.

“Hi, Mom and Dad,” Glimmer said with a nervous grin as everyone climbed out onto the docks.

“I think that makes the fifth outboard you’ve burned out,” her dad said with a shake of his head. “Makes you the ace of motor destruction.”

“That’s her dad,” Bow whispered to Adora and Catra. “His name’s Micah.”

“Glimmer, what were you thinking!? You knew the weather was getting bad! You could have driven up the road and picked up

Frosta that way!" her mom said before looking at Adora and Catra. "And I'm sorry but who are you?"

"Her mom, Angella," Bow whispered to Adora.

Adora stepped forward and because she was holding Catra's hand without even realizing it meant that Catra came with her.

"Ma'am, please forgive her for this. My name is Adora and this is my friend Catra. We had fallen in the river and were really struggling. She rescued us," Adora said.

"Mom, I told you about seeing her last night, remember? They're from across the river," Glimmer said.

"Is this some weird camp stunt?" Angella said, confusion taking over from her irritation.

"It's a long story, ma'am," Catra said as she looked at Adora. "Us being in the river was an accident though."

Angella just sighed as she said, "Bow, please take them back to their camp as soon as possible and use the bus. I do not need more trouble with that man and having two of his campers here will cause that. Frosta, young lady, come with me. We need to have a talk."

Frosta, who'd just been kind of hanging out behind Adora and Catra trying to look inconspicuous, sighed as she nodded and walked up beside Angella.

"I have a good reason," she said.

"And I'd love to hear it. Now come on," Angella said with a little smile and a shake of her head.

Micah looked at Glimmer as he said, "Looking forward to you helping me re-build that outboard tomorrow, Ace."

"Yes, *father,"* Glimmer said with a smile. Micah laughed and stepped up to hug her before moving along after Angella.

Adora looked at the two parents as Micah walked up and took Angella's hand. She looked at Glimmer and then down at the still smoking outboard. Then she thought about everything that had happened as she sat staring at the outboard.

"No, no, no, no," Adora started to mutter. "Mom told me to behave. I'm supposed to behave. I'm supposed to be good. The Fifth Commandment is there for a reason."

Catra squeezed Adora's hand as she put her other hand on her shoulder. Bow and Glimmer were looking at Adora wide eyed as Angella and Micah stopped and turned to see what was going on.

"I've damned her. I've damned her. It's clear, Proverbs 10:7, whoever heeds discipline shows the way to life, but whoever ignores correction leads others astray," Adora said as she kept staring at the motor as she began to shake. "What have I done!?"

"Is she OK?" Bow asked as Glimmer started to tentatively move towards Adora.

"I don't know," Catra said. "Adora? You alright?"

Adora looked up at Catra and pulled her hand away from Catra as she stepped back shaking her head.

"I… I… I don't know…," Adora said as the shaking got harder.

"Adora, how about you sit down for a moment?" Glimmer said as she started to get a little closer.

Catra gave Adora a tired smile as she said, "Hey, calm down. It's alright, it's going to work out. I'm sorry about earlier. We'll work it out somehow. We're still friends. We'll stick together, side by side, bone of my bone, flesh of my flesh, and all that."

Adora stopped shaking as the words Catra was saying sank in. She didn't know if Catra used the words from Genesis for a reason or if she was just grabbed onto them as a way to say that they were in it together but they hit Adora like a ton of bricks and tears started falling down her face.

"Adora?" Catra said and Adora didn't think she'd ever heard her name said in such a beautiful way before but she knew there was only one way to address this.

"Fuck it," she said and stepped forward. Her hands found the sides of Catra's head, one on the side of her face, the other hand higher up in her hair, just like she'd been taught to heal a person by touch, and pulled Catra's face to her own.

It wasn't a perfect kiss. It wasn't a gentle movie kiss while violins and cellos soared in the background. It was a desperate kiss, a kiss denied for too long, and for a split second Catra froze as she thought she was still in the river and drowning and this was the last thing she was imagining but then her arms wrapped around Adora and she was kissing her back and like back in the chapel she felt like she was lit by fire and not consumed but she also now felt like she was floating above the floor, buoyed up on the holy flames of love. She held Adora tighter than she had when they were being swept away by flood waters and tears flowed down their faces and mingled together as Adora's hands fell from Catra's head to pull her closer.

They finally pulled apart as they ran out of air, placing their foreheads against each other as they stared into the other's eyes.

Neither knew what to say as they started to laugh, tears flowing down their faces. They both were shaking and Catra leaned in and kissed Adora again before they both laughed again, so full of joy neither could contain it.

"Phileo love?" Catra said as she grinned at Adora.

"No, pretty sure it's not," Adora said, blushing a deep red as a shudder ran through her. "I love you, Catra, *I love you."*

"I love you too," Catra said, her voice breaking into a happy sob as she hugged Adora tight. Then the two realized that there were other people around them, mostly because Frosta wouldn't stop shouting, "Woooooo!" at the top of her lungs.

Catra looked over at Glimmer and Bow. Glimmer had her arm linked through Bow's arm and was leaning her head onto his shoulder with a smile on her face. Bow had his free hand up covering his mouth as he was trying, and failing, to repress gleeful little noises of happiness.

"I don't even know you two but I need you to stop looking at us like that please," Catra said to the two of them as deadpan as she could manage while Adora buried her face in Catra's shoulder as she blushed even harder and laughed.

"I'm sorry, I'm sorry," Bow said with a grin and then they all turned when they heard Angella speak up.

“Glimmer, could you please come over here for a moment?”

“I’ll be right back,” Glimmer said as she kissed Bow’s cheek and then went over to her mother who was still standing by the door.

“It’s alright, Adora,” Bow said as he stepped up beside them. “There’s no reason to be embarrassed.”

“I’m fine,” Adora’s muffled voice came from Catra’s shoulder as she flapped her hand at Bow. Catra leaned down and gently kissed the top of Adora’s head and the hand flapped faster. Adora pulled her head back as she looked at Catra with the happiest smile she’d ever seen.

“Hey! If you two can stop canoodling for a moment, are you both eighteen or older!?” Glimmer shouted from where she was standing. Catra looked at her weirdly before saying yes. Glimmer looked at Angella who nodded and Glimmer turned back to them. “In that case, Mom says you can both stay here if you want. Sanctuary or whatever.”

Adora’s smile fled as she realized just what all this meant but instead of desperation, her face was full of determination. Catra just nodded as she said, “Thanks. We’ll probably take you up on that.”

“We’ll talk in the morning,” Angella said before finally walking out into the dying rain storm while Frosta gave one last woo and a fist pump. They heard Micah laughing as he walked after the other two.

“I guess we can get you a place in one of the counselor cabins or something,” Glimmer said. “And some dry clothes.”

“No,” Adora said and the three looked at her. “We can’t stop yet. We have to go find Lynda. We can’t leave her behind.”

“Do you have any idea how?” Bow asked, not asking who Lynda was while Glimmer just nodded and started yanking the gas tank out of the boat they’d come in and moving it to another one

“No,” Adora said. “But Luke 15 says we go for the lost sheep. So we go.”

As Adora went after Glimmer to get into the boat, Bow looked at Catra as he said, “Is she always like that?”

“You have no idea,” Catra said with a delighted smile.

Chapter End Notes

Editing that kiss scene to Dolly Parton’s version of Stairway to Heaven was just *chefs kiss*.

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora head back to the camp to find Lynda.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It'd been a simple plan they'd come up with as they got into the boat. Motor across the river as night fell, drop Catra and Adora off upstream of the bluff where they could follow a trail Catra knew up to the barn, and see if Lynda was there. Then if not, quietly move through camp to see if they could figure anything out, before sneaking back to the boat. Simple and easy. It didn't go that way.

As they motored across the river, the rain having finally died off, Bow handed Catra a little handheld radio.

"What's this for?" Catra said as she held it up.

"It's a walkie-talkie," Bow said.

Catra rolled her eyes as she said, "I know what it is but what's it for?"

“We use them around the camp. I’ve got one here and you can let us know when you’re coming back,” Bow said.

“Do we do code names again?” Glimmer said with glee.

“No, we’re not doing code names. Not after last time,” Bow said.

“What was last time?” Adora said.

“He didn’t like being called Bowseph as his code name,” Glimmer said with a gleeful smile.

“Bowseph you say,” Catra said with an answering smile.

“No,” Bow said. “Absolutely not.”

Adora wasn’t paying attention though as she watched the shore rapidly approaching. Catra nodded and leaned over to her.

“You sure about this?” Catra said. Adora just nodded and soon the boat was pushing up into a little pool. Adora jumped over the side and was wading up towards the shore as Catra just shook her head.

“We’ll call you,” she said as she slipped the radio into her pocket.

“I’m going to move us upstream a little,” Glimmer said. “When you’re ready, call on channel three, seven as backup. If you give me a five minute heads up, I can be pretty much anywhere on this river to meet you.”

“Aiming for motor number six already?” Catra said as she hopped off the boat.

“You don’t know me well enough to tease me like that,” Glimmer said with a grin.

“I’m just mad she beat me to it,” Bow said as he used a paddle to push them back into the current.

Catra sloshed ashore as Adora was looking up the trail that went right down to the waterline.

“You alright?” Catra said quietly.

“Are we really going to just give up… everything?” Adora said.

Catra took her hand as the two stood there on the edge of the river.

“What am I giving up? A crappy foster family back home and that’s about it. You don’t have to though,” Catra said quietly. “I can find Lynda and go back with those two. You can say you were, I don’t know, praying or something. You might get some grief but you’ll come out of it. We can keep in touch somehow.”

Adora thought about it. She could probably keep in secret touch with Catra. She could sneak off on weekends at college to go see her. Maybe she could eventually get her mom around to understanding who she was as a person. She could still try and have what she had always wanted while getting to keep what she had now. However, standing there in the mud beside the river as the last of the rain blew away, she turned to Catra and in her mind saw the flames burning away what her life would have been. She wasn’t sure what it would be going forward but she knew exactly how she felt.

“No one can serve two masters. I won’t lie about myself anymore,” Adora said.

“Adora…,” Catra started to say and Adora cut her off as she gently cupped her face.

“Remember? Where you go I will go, and where you stay I will stay,” Adora said. “Ruth 1:16, your favorite verse. I really was blind wasn’t I?”

Catra nodded, tears in her eyes as she leaned forward and kissed Adora before pulling back.

"But now you see. Let's find Lynda," Catra said.

When they reached the top of the hill, they could see the barn ahead of them. A single small light glowed at the front in the early evening gloom, a few moths starting to gather around it after the rain. The two carefully made their way forward, looking every which way but not seeing anyone. Catra quietly went over the corral fence and in through the rear of the barn while Adora waited in the trees, trying to stay calm as she nervously shifted back and forth. It seemed like forever but was only about five minutes before Catra was back over the fence and back in the trees with Adora.

"Nothing. The checklist is updated but I didn't see anything else," Catra said. "Now what?"

"We go up into camp," Adora said.

"And if we run into someone?" Catra said.

Adora shook her head as she said, "They're either all still buttoned up in their cabins because of the storm or everyone will be at chapel. We shouldn't see anyone."

“You sure about this?” Catra said.

Adora shook her head but started forward anyway and Catra was right on her heels. They stuck to the trees as they went along and went around a few silent, empty cabins.

“They must be at the chapel,” Adora said quietly.

“What if Lynda is at the chapel as well?” Catra replied.

“I… I have no idea,” Adora said.

“You going to just storm in there with the power of God and lesbian wrath on your side?” Catra said with a little nudge to Adora.

Adora blushed as she heard lesbian applied to herself. She couldn’t deny it of course but it still felt extremely weird to apply it to herself. Then she realized she was holding Catra’s hand and had done so as soon as they’d stopped to talk. That didn’t feel weird at all and she realized that saying lesbian was just another way to denote the kind of love she felt, like the Greeks using phileo or agape. She squeezed Catra’s hand as she responded.

“Ummm, I don’t know,” Adora said. “How long you think Glimmer and Bow will wait for us?”

Catra shrugged as she swatted at a bug.

“More like how long will we wait getting eaten up out here,” Catra said. “Let me find out.”

She pulled out the little radio and turned it on. She made sure the volume was down low and keyed it up.

“Bowseph, you there?” Catra said.

Back in the boat, Glimmer and Bow were tied up under an overhanging tree with the motor off and Glimmer snickered as she heard Bow sigh and key up the radio.

“Are you ready, over?” Bow said.

“How long are you going to hang out waiting?” Catra said quietly back.

Bow looked at Glimmer who was applying some bug spray. She looked back at him and shrugged.

“I got nothing pressing this evening,” Glimmer said. “My cabin is covered for the evening.”

Bow nodded and keyed the radio back up.

“Long as you need, over,” Bow said.

“Why does he keep saying that?” Catra said.

“I think you’re supposed to when you’re done,” Adora said back.

Catra shook her head as she keyed up again, “OK. Just checking. Turning this thing off again.”

Catra didn’t wait for a response and shut it off.

“Now what?” Catra said.

Adora said, “We go up by the toolshed by the pool. We have a full view of the main camp from up there and the parking lot is nearby. We try to see Lynda and get her to follow us. Then we run for it.”

Catra looked at her for a long moment before she said, " *That's* your plan!?"

"You have a better one?" Adora said.

Catra stared at her before she shook her head and started forward through the trees. It wasn't long before they came to the area of the main camp and could see the chapel lit up and they could both hear Joshua preaching at full volume. The words weren't apparent but the tone was one of fire and damnation.

"That doesn't sound good," Adora said from where they were crouched down by the toolshed by the pool.

"I hope she's not in there," Catra said. Then they both suddenly flattened out on the ground as they heard a car pulling into the parking area where the buses normally unloaded.

"Who's here?" Adora whispered and then they both jumped to their feet when they heard the toolshed door open and saw two people walking out hand in hand with huge duffels over their shoulders.

"Rogelio?! Kyle!?" Adora said, barely remembering to keep her voice down.

The two spun around to see Catra and Adora crouched down at the side of the toolshed and then they both relaxed and quickly scurried over to them.

"Where have you two been!?" Kyle said.

"It's a long story," Adora said. "What are you two doing?"

"Leaving," Kyle said. "Joshua is in there in full rant about the evils of homosexuality and the insidious nature of the devil and all that… bullshit! We're tired of it and we figure we can find something else."

Rogelio gave him a side arm hug and suddenly Catra was grinning as she pointed at the two of them. Adora didn't get it at first and then suddenly her eyes widened.

"Yes, he's my boyfriend and don't you dare start preaching at us," Kyle said.

"I'd be a hypocrite to do that in front of my girlfriend," Catra said as she hooked her thumb at Adora.

"What!?" Kyle said. "Since when!?"

Adora, blushing hard, said, “About two hours?”

“That explains a lot,” Kyle said. “Listen. Bail now. Lynda already has as far as we can tell and we got a friend waiting for us over in the parking lot.”

“And she’s tired of waiting on you two. What the hell is going on over here?” a voice from the darkness said as everyone jumped.

Adora turned to see a woman in a heavy metal band t-shirt with her hair pulled back in a bandana walking up to them.

“I’m not waiting around. You coming or not?” she said.

“Sorry, Lonnie, yeah, we’re going,” Kyle said as Rogelio went over and lifted Lonnie up off the ground in a hug.

“Lynda is really gone?” Catra said.

“Yep,” Kyle said. “Her stuff is all gone and I heard someone say Joshua was ticked off about it for some reason. Listen, we gotta go, keep in touch you two.”

“You too,” Adora said as she stepped up and hugged Kyle. Catra stepped up behind her and did the same as Rogelio came over

and wrapped them all up in his arms. The hug didn't last long. Catra and Adora watched the three disappear into the dark and a few minutes later they watched a car go past them on the road out, lights out but the radio up as high as it would go as a song screamed "Run to the hills" through the open car window.

"We gotta go," Catra said. "Right now."

"Go to your cabin and grab what you need," Adora said. "I'll do the same. We meet back at the barn by the path."

"Not a chance. We are not splitting up," Catra said. "My cabin is closer. Come on."

"Catra..," Adora started to say.

"Nope, come on," Catra said and grabbed Adora's hand and went running. No one was at Catra's cabin and Adora stood outside watching as she heard Catra quickly pack up. She was out with a duffel bag in her hand in just a few minutes.

They ran through the trees towards Adora's cabin. They slowed to make sure no one was around before Adora went inside. Once inside, she paused and looked around with a sigh. The cabin wasn't much but she remembered staying in one just like it every summer for years. It hadn't been all bad and the memories flicked up as she took a deep breath and wiped away a tear, shaking her

head. She could feel she was doing the right thing but even the right thing could hurt.

She threw her footlocker open and pulled a duffle bag out, stuffing clothes and toiletries in. Right before she left, she picked up her Bible and looked at it. It was a heavy study Bible and it had her name engraved on the front, a prize from some church event that she couldn't even remember at the moment. She looked at it and then shoved it and her concordance into her duffel and zipped it shut. She looked one last time and was getting ready to go when she heard Catra knock fast on the door.

Adora went out and felt her heart drop. Joshua was walking up the path, Octavia and a few other counselors behind him, and following them, the girls from her cabin as well as the other cabins nearby.

"Do we run?" Catra said, already starting to back up.

"You two!" Joshua thundered. "You two deviants will stay right where you are! You are in a lot of trouble!"

Catra watched Adora's face go from scared to angry.

"Hey, I was kidding about that power of God and lesbian wrath thing," Catra said quickly and quietly.

Adora was standing on the steps coming down from her cabin and so she was a bit taller than everyone. It reminded her of the few times she'd stood in the pulpit for one reason or another. She saw the kids from her cabin looking at her in confusion. She saw the counselors, some of them with bored looks on their faces, and others with looks like they were ready for a show. She immediately spun up to a full voiced shout, one that wouldn't have been the least bit out of place behind a pulpit.

"Deviant!? How dare you call us deviants! Liar! Scoundrel! Abuser! You twist the word of God to suit your own ends, you sow fear and confusion among the faithful, and have the gall to call me a deviant!?" Adora yelled at him. The crowd stopped only a few dozen feet away as Joshua continued forward.

"Don't you dare speak to me that way! You don't think I won't throw you both out of here!?" Joshua shouted. "You both should kneel down right now and beg forgiveness for your sins! You think the Lord Our God doesn't see what you do in the dark and twisted places of your souls or the sickness in your hearts!? You flaunt your grotesque nature before these children!? Repent now and save your souls and your future!"

Adora unzipped her duffel and yanked her Bible out.

"You condemn me and spew hate while you do so! Hate is not from our Lord God! Hate is a tool of the Deceiver!" Adora screamed as she looked down at Joshua who was now only a few feet in front of her. Catra had shrunk back and had her back firmly against the cabin now as Joshua laughed.

“Brandish your Bible all you want! Even the Devil knows scripture!” Joshua said.

“How convenient to say that! How easy it is to refute anything I might say!” Adora said and raised her Bible high as if she was ready to strike Joshua down with it. “The truth of the Lord’s words will shine through though! First John chapter four says it clearly! God is love! But more importantly, *there is no fear in love!”*

Adora looked at the crowd behind Joshua as she held a hand out to Catra. “Do you hear me!? There is no fear in love! I’m no longer afraid to admit my love for this woman!”

Joshua started to step up and Adora looked down at him. There was anger in his eyes and before she would have fallen away from that face. She’d been afraid of him ever since she’d first met him. She’d been afraid of his judgment, she’d been afraid of the words he spoke, and she’d always felt small before him and even at that point, she could feel the need to apologize and seek forgiveness from him rising up. The difference though was she no longer felt small. As Joshua reached up to grab her arm, Adora stepped forward, putting him off balance, and forcing him backwards down the steps.

“Do not touch me! Get thee behind me!”

Adora watched Joshua step back, frozen into inaction by the anger pouring off Adora as she turned to Catra.

“We’re leaving now,” Adora said, her voice strong as she stepped around Joshua, took Catra’s hand, and began to walk off.

“You get back here right now!” Joshua screamed. “You will not defy me! Come back here right now!”

Catra looked at Adora. Adora’s face was full of anger but she straightened her back and walked on. Catra put her arm around Adora’s waist and walked with her through the shadows of the evening, fearing no evil.

Chapter End Notes

Give it up for *Run to the Hills* by Iron Maiden and the most thematically appropriate song for Lonnie to be blaring as she takes those two out. She knows how to make an exit.

This is the second to the last chapter. The next one will be an epilogue.

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

Afterwards...

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The rest of the summer was the weirdest one in Adora's life to that point. The next day, Adora had been introduced to a woman who called herself Mermista. Adora had tried to ask and Mermista had just rolled her eyes and said it was a camp nickname and she didn't want to go into it. Mermista was showing her some office work that Adora had agreed to do when her mother had come storming into the office.

"Adora Eileen Weaver, what in the name of God are you doing!?" Ms. Weaver shouted. Adora scrambled to her feet, the reaction automatic in the presence of her mother. "I'm already being told your scholarship to college is being revoked and you're more than likely going to be denied entry! You get in the car right this instant! We are going to sort this out right now!"

"Ma'am, let me explain," Adora started to say and her mother was across the room in shot and standing over Adora.

"Do not speak! Do not even look at me! No child of mine will be a dyke and you will not talk back to me! Shut your mouth and get in

that car!” Ms. Weaver shouted as she pointed behind her towards the door and grabbed Adora’s arm.

Mermista calmly stood up and stepped up to Adora’s side as she said, “Lady, don’t use that language here. Also, let her go and step back before I knock you back.”

Adora, shaking, looked at Mermista in shock. She didn’t see her mom’s eyes go wide around her sunglasses as she said in shock, “What did you say to me!?”

“I said step back…,” Mermista said as she started to pick up a heavy stapler off the desk and then she was cut off by Micah as he came out of his office.

“Mista! I have this,” Micah said and stepped forward. “Ma’am, my name is Micah and we can talk about this calmly.”

“Stay out of this! This a family matter,” Ms. Weaver said. “Adora, come with me, now!”

Micah stepped up to the desk as he said, “Adora, do you want to go with her?”

Adora almost said yes because she was terrified of saying no. She was shaking as she looked at her mother then she shook her head no, not trusting her voice to reply.

“Is that a no?” Micah said, not taking his eye off Ms. Weaver.

“That’s correct,” Adora croaked out as she backed up, breaking her mother’s grasp on her arm.

“You will not keep my daughter from me!” Ms. Weaver said.

“She’s doing that on her own,” Micah said as he stepped between Ms. Weather and Adora. “Now leave. You’re not welcome here.”

“I will call the police!” Ms. Weaver said.

“Call the county sheriff, she has jurisdiction out here but call her from the road because if you’re not off my property in five minutes, I’m pressing trespassing charges and anything else I can manage,” Micah replied as several more people came running into the room.

“Adora,” Ms. Weaver said, her voice going sweet as she looked at Adora. “Don’t do this. You’re going to ruin your life for some infatuation, some sin.”

Adora was crying as she held herself tight and looked her mother in the eyes.

“I love you, Mom, but I’m not going with you. We can talk about this here.”

“We will not do this in front of these people,” Ms. Weaver said, her voice getting harsh again. “Get in the car.”

Adora just shook her head and Ms. Weaver said, “Then you’re dead to me,” before storming out.

Adora was crying on the floor in the office and Catra was holding her, rocking her gently when the sheriff showed up an hour later. Micah spoke with the sheriff for a few minutes before the sheriff came over and knelt down next to Adora. After a few more minutes, Adora walked off with the sheriff by her car. Catra sat on the porch of the office, watching and nervously thumping her foot as they all waited. Fifteen minutes later, Adora came back and Catra hugged her tight. The sheriff beckoned Micah over and spoke with him for a few minutes in private before driving off.

That evening Adora wrote a long letter to her mother, using Biblical quotes and saying exactly how she felt and why and sent it off. The only response she received was her mail getting forwarded to the camp and the unopened letter with return to sender written on the outside. Adora spent a lot of time in silence as she thought about what had happened and there were several times she almost called her mother to apologize and try and work it out but she’d have the phone up and half dialed before she’d finally just set it down with a sigh. Catra didn’t have it quite as hard, cutting herself off from a foster family that had barely

tolerated her especially after turning eighteen hadn't been as hard, but she still understood and did her best to comfort Adora.

The two stayed the summer in a small camper trailer behind Micah and Angella's home and Adora remembered the second day they were in there, trying to make some sense of everything and unpacking. Catra had been going through her duffel bag and suddenly grinned.

"I know what will make this feel better," Catra said and as Adora turned to see what she meant, saw Catra unfolding some wadded up paper towels. Then she plucked something out of it, turned around, and held out a cut glass crystal.

"What? Where did you get those?" Adora said as she reached her hand out and took it from Catra. She could see more nestled in the paper towels.

"Out of the trash last year," Catra said. "After you threw them out, I got them out. I held onto them ever since at the bottom of my shower bag. Forgot they were even in my stuff until just now."

Adora sniffled a little as she held it up in the late afternoon sunlight coming through the window and watched as rainbows danced around the space. They hung up all of them in another window and they would catch the morning sun coming up so they could wake up to rainbows around them. The rest of the summer Adora and Catra helped around the camp. Catra worked at the horse barn again at her insistence and met the farrier. She took a real interest in that work and began to learn the craft. They hung

out with Glimmer and Bow, as well as the rest of the counselors, and Adora ended up having long conversations about religion late into the evening with some of the people. Scorpia caught up with them a few weeks after they'd moved into Camp Bright Moon and told them her story. She had been living out with Tara and her wife and was in constant contact with her mother and her wife and was planning on moving there at the end of the summer. They talked with Kyle and Rogelio as well and even met their friend Lonnie more formally when they came by the camp for a few days.

As fall came closer, both Adora and Catra got nervous. Angella had helped them both get their vital documents since their respective families had refused to help them out. Catra dropped out of college before it even began and planned to keep at the farrier work while Adora managed to get into a school in a nearby large town that Glimmer was going to attend. Things were going as well as could be expected but they both kept waiting for the other shoe to drop. They might love each other but the world was still the world and it loomed up as the evenings got a little longer each day. It was the last night before the last group of campers came for the last session of the summer and they were all sitting around on the porch at Angella and Micah's home when Micah finally spoke up after noticing their unease.

"You two seem jumpy lately," Micah said to Catra and Adora.

"It's nothing, sir," Adora said. Everyone had given up weeks before trying to get her to stop saying that to older adults.

"Adora, you can't lie at all," Bow said. "What's going on?"

Catra and Adora looked at each other, holding the other's hand, before Adora said, "We're worried about the fall. You've all been very helpful but… I don't know. It's summer camp. I don't know what happens after."

"Seriously?" Glimmer said. "You go to college. Catra sees you when she's not wrestling with horses," Catra stuck her tongue at Glimmer as Glimmer went on. "We hang out and learn stuff. What's to worry about?"

Angella leaned forward as she said, "You're worried we're going to drift off."

Adora didn't move but Catra nodded.

"If I haven't made it clear," Angella said softly, "you both are like family to us. You are always welcome here. We may not be your parents but you can always come to us for help, winter, spring, summer or fall."

Micah took her hand and agreed with her. It felt good to hear and it did help but the proof is always in the doing, not the saying, and as time went on everyone just kept on doing to show they meant what they said.

Fall came on. Adora went to school. Catra saw her as much as possible as she traveled and learned. It wasn't perfect but the world isn't perfect and they made the most of it. They had fights but they made up. They had misunderstandings but they worked them out. Adora struggled as she realized portions of her schooling had been inadequate but she pushed through. Years went past.

It was early fall six years later and Catra and Adora were both sitting outside a small bookshop and cafe at a comfortable table in golden late afternoon light. They were a few blocks from their apartment on the edge of the university campus that Adora was attending as she worked on her masters in Religious Studies. Catra still worked as a farrier, supporting them both for the most part, and was branching out into other kinds of metalwork.

"I can't believe that place is buying up all these artifacts," Adora grouched. "They won't let people even look at it if they don't agree to let them see and approve their research."

"You can always do it and then just tuck your research away and scream 'Get thee behind me!' at them when they try to look at it," Catra said as she sipped at her soda. Adora laughed as she shook her head.

"Never going to let me live that down are you?" Adora said.

"Are you kidding? Let my wife forget one of the coolest damn things I've ever seen? Absolutely not," Catra said and then her eyes drifted to a young woman walking down the sidewalk. She

had multi-colored hair with an undercut, a jean jacket covered in patches and pins, and a huge shoulder bag. On top of it, she had the slightly confused and worried look that they both recognized as a new freshman trying to figure out all their new found freedom.

"The baby gays just get younger and younger don't they?" Catra said with a grin as they both spotted the pride pins.

"Nah, we just get older," Adora said and then looked a little closer. Something seemed familiar about the woman. The woman was looking at Adora, discretely or so she thought, as she walked past and then finally stopped by the little iron fence around the outdoor seating area.

"Hi, I'm sorry to bother you but are you Adora Weaver?" the woman said.

Adora kept feeling a memory tickle her mind that wouldn't quite surface as she held up her left hand to show the simple silver band on her ring finger as she said, "Well, not Weaver anymore but yeah, that's me. I'm sorry but I can't place you."

The woman said, "You were my camp counselor the last year you were at camp. My name is Kaitlyn."

The memory crashed in on Adora then as she stood up and leaned forward to hug her. There were a few awkward minutes as

Adora got her to come and sit down with them. Finally Adora said, "That was a wild summer for me. I'm so sorry everything happened like it did but it's really good to see you. What have you been up to?"

Kaitlyn looked down as she fiddled with a napkin on the table as she said, "College mostly but, uh, I should… I should probably say that summer and all that stuff you went through, that was my fault."

"What do you mean?" Adora said but Catra was nodding as something she had long suspected was being confirmed.

"You told Joshua about Scorpia and I didn't you?" Catra said gently.

Kaitlyn looked at her confused but said, "You mean Lynda?" Catra said yes and Kaitlyn nodded back. "Melanie saw you two and I saw some of it and we thought that… it was stupid vengeful twelve year old crap that we didn't think through. I felt wrong about it almost immediately. I'm sorry."

Adora reached out and placed a hand on Kaitlyn's hand as she said, "Hey, it's alright. You were just kids, like you said, and it's long past. Besides, forgive us our trespasses as we forgive those who trespass against us. Matthew, chapter six, remember?"

Kaitlyn looked at her confused as she said, “You’re still into all of that?”

Catra snorted as she said, “She’s working on her masters degree in all of that.”

“I don’t understand. Aren’t you…,” Kaitlyn said and then pointed at one of her Pride pins.

“Yes, but that doesn’t mean I can’t find meaning in God, whoever They may be,” Adora said. “After all, we’re all imperfect…”

Catra cut her off by giving Adora’s chair a little nudge with her foot as she said to Kaitlyn, “Sorry, had to get her early or she’ll give us a sermon.”

“You said you liked it,” Adora said, with mock outrage.

“I do because I love you,” Catra said with a grin and Adora’s heart melted just like it had one stormy night years before.

“So what’s your story? What are you doing running around a secular college town wearing Pride pins and an awesome hairstyle?” Catra said as she took Adora’s hand.

Kaitlyn grinned a little as she said, “Well, I’m here because Nicoletta is here. Do you remember her?” Adora and Catra both nodded and Kaitlyn went on. “We dated really briefly last year but stayed friends and we both ended up coming here.”

Adora laughed as she said, “Dated!? I remember you two not getting along but you especially didn’t with Bethany.”

Kaitlyn blushed as she said, “Because I had a crush on her and didn’t understand what was going on.”

Adora looked at her and then suddenly went red herself as she remembered those two nights and some of the things she had said.

“I may not have been the best role model for you all.”

Kaitlyn shook her head as she said, “You actually were part of the reason I came out. I mean, you were the first person I ever knew who was openly gay and you came out in front of all of us while screaming about love and not being afraid. Took me a few years but I finally came out as well. It helped that my parents weren’t nightmares about it, although it took a bit of getting used to for them, but they’re supportive now.”

Adora smiled, hiding her ache at the loss of her own relationship with her mother, as she said, “Good. I’m happy to hear it. Do you still keep in touch with anyone else?”

"A few," Kaitlyn said and began to talk about some of the girls from the cabin and what they had been up to. Adora and Catra filled her in on what they had been up to as well as the others and briefly talked about Joshua getting arrested for fraud and embezzlement from the camp a few years before. The conversation drifted back and forth and then Kaitlyn got to Melanie and gave a rueful laugh. "We don't really talk anymore. She said she was alright with the whole gay thing but she really wasn't and we drifted. She's OK, grew up like we all did, but we're just different people, that's all."

They all shook their heads. They'd all changed but that was just the way of the world. As Adora would have said, change was the only constant, as it was in the beginning, is now, and ever shall be, world without end. After a few more minutes, the three stood up as the street lights started to flick on. There were hugs and exchanges of contact information and promises to come for dinner and then Kaitlyn was walking down the street while Catra and Adora headed towards their apartment.

Once inside, Adora headed for the kitchen to check the crock pot she'd started that morning and Catra sat down at their little table. Crystals hung in the window and seemed to spark as they moved a little and caught the lights from the street. Catra heard Adora singing as she got things ready. She still knew Adora's top songs and most of them had changed but this one was still number one. When she'd asked Adora why before, Adora had said, "Because it feels even more true now than when I first learned it."

Now Catra sat at the window and hummed along as Adora sang loudly as she started to put food onto plates for the two of them.

“Amazing grace, how sweet the sound, that saved a wretch like me. I once was lost, but now I’m found, was blind, but now I see.”

Chapter End Notes

This turned into way, way more than I expected it to be. I say that a lot on my longer stories but this one really has been something else. Thank you to each and every one of you who came along on this ride with me. I write for myself but I post for everyone else so I’m really happy to see how much everyone has enjoyed and engaged with this. Thank you.

As you can imagine, this one was personal to me. I’ve never done an AU before because it wasn’t something that ever really clicked with me. Then back in the summer of 2021, I saw someone say summer camp AU. I’d seen summer camp AU’s for SPOP before and read some and really liked it. Then church camp came to mind and I started kind of riffing on it and then suddenly I thought, “Hey, I can do this,” because I grew up in a church similar to ones that Catra and Adora would have attended. I had some things to say about it. So I wrote the first chapter. Then it just sat there because I was already moving into what would become my longest piece of work I ever wrote, The Heir Apparent, and that consumed something like eight months of time as I wrote it, edited it, and posted that one. Then, when I was finishing up with that, I thought, “I need a bit of a break. I’ll do some short fics and oh! I can get that church camp AU out. Just kind of do it sporadically, no real rush on it.”

We all see how that went. I normally write longer fics with huge buffers and update a week at a time. This one I was usually only one chapter ahead and updating almost every day. I don’t regret it though because this really has been fun to write and I said some things I felt needed saying even while I relived some things I had forgotten about. I also

enjoyed interacting with everyone in the comments and I have to say to those who've said some variety of, "Wow, this seems really shocking!" I ummm, actually toned it down a little. Mostly in the language and especially around the transphobic stuff. Partly because it's a Teen rating but mostly because I just didn't want to include it. It was already bad enough.

So what's next for me? Probably that break I keep swearing I'll take… assuming I don't work on more of my two ongoing series, short stand-alones as they occur to me, and any other absolutely amazing ideas that might come to me. Like one I have about Hordak in the Bright Moon "prison" and how he feels about pillows. Or one of grown up Finn dealing with one of their biological parents. Or of Capella, my OC that's Bow and Glimmer's daughter, and some childhood shenanigans. You get the idea.

I wanted to close with a fact about me: I'm an ordained minister. Now that doesn't mean much since in the US you can make that happen online for free and the paperwork you have to file with your local municipality to make it where you can do things like perform marriages is something like $20. I don't run a church or anything like that. I got ordained to marry an acquaintance's sister as a favor and I've married a few other people over the years. I got to write an entire ceremony with the couple for the last one I did a couple of years ago and I wrote something that I love so much in that. I want to share it here because it's part of what I meant when I said, "the holy flames of love" in chapter eleven.

"To love yourself and others is a radical act in our world and to express that for the world to see as {person A} and {person B} have chosen to do is extraordinary because if God is love then any expression of love is to see God manifesting in this world."

I don't have faith in religion anymore. I'm not sure what God is and on bad days I'm not sure if there is such a thing but I

believe love is holy. I believe what I said above though that to see love is to see the very purest manifestation of what I recognize as God in this world. That's what I love about She-Ra. That message that love can save the universe and love can save us. That's an important thing I believe, because in a world that profits from our hate for ourselves and others, love is a radical act. I hope you enjoyed this fic and I hope you carry that message forward from this. Thank you for reading.

Chapter 12: Partial Re-Write

Chapter Summary

> This is a re-write of part of chapter twelve from a couple of years down the line from when I originally posted it. The reason is better laid out in the chapter notes but know it's not because I disliked anything about the original, I just saw a chance to put something a little different in it.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They ran through the trees towards Adora's cabin, the air full of little noises from wind in the trees and noises of insects waking in the darkness. As they approached the cabin, they both slowed, looking around, trying to be sure they weren't seen before Adora slipped inside.

Once inside, she stood still for a moment and let out a long sigh. It wasn't much, wood floors and simple bunk beds with screens over the windows to keep the bugs out, but she'd stayed in a cabin like it ever summer for years. Even now, as she began to open her footlocker to pack and run, memories flickered up, good memories, and she had to take a deep breath and fight down a tear as she began to stuff clothes and toiletries into a duffle bag. She knew it was the right move, she knew what she was doing was what should be, but she was learning that even the right thing could hurt.

As she stood to leave, she picked up her Bible from the shelf over her bed and held it in her hand as she looked at her name, Adora Weaver, engraved on the front. She remembered winning it as a prize from some church event that she couldn't even remember at the moment and how proud she'd been that she'd had a real adult-style study Bible. She began to toss it back on the shelf

before suddenly shaking her and shoving it into her duffle before grabbing her concordance off the shelf to join it. She looked around one last time and then jumped when she heard Catra knock fast on the door.

When she went out the door, she felt her heart drop as she saw Joshua walking up the path flanked by several counselors and then following behind them, the girls from her cabin as well as what looked like at least half the camp.

“Let's go," Catra said, already starting to back up.

“You!” Joshua thundered. “You two deviants will stay right where you are!”

Adora's heart stopped and she felt a strange lightness suffuse her as she straightened up. Catra looked up at Adora's face, saw the expression that had settled there, and said quietly, "Hey, I was kidding about that power of God and lesbian wrath thing earlier."

From her perch atop the stairs, Adora could see out over everyone and it reminded her of the few times she'd been able to stand in a pulpit. She saw the kids from her cabin looking confused, she saw the counselors looking either bored or ready for a show, but what she focused on was Joshua's face and with that firmly in place, she immediately let out with a voice that wouldn't have been out of place behind a pulpit at all.

“How dare you! Liar! Scoundrel! Abuser! You twist the word of God and have the gall to shout deviant to anyone!?”

The crowd stopped only a few dozen feet away as Joshua continued forward.

“You don’t think I won’t throw you both out of here!?” Joshua shouted. “Kneel down, the both of you, and beg forgiveness for your sins! You think the Lord Our God doesn’t see what you do or how you feel in the dark and twisted places of your souls!? You think he doesn't see the sickness in your hearts, the filth in your minds!? Repent! Repent and pray for mercy!"

Adora had her Bible out, clutched tight in her hand, as she looked down at Joshua as she screamed back, "Filth!? Sickness!? The only sickness I see is your infection of hate from the Deceiver! I know the truth now and as it is promised in John, it has set me free!

Joshua was only a few feet in front of Adora now as Catra shrunk back until her back was firmly against the cabin.

"Brandish your Bible all you want! Even the Devil knows scripture!" Joshua said.

"How convenient! How easy to refute anything I might say!" Adora said and raised her Bible high as if she was ready to strike Joshua down with it. "The truth of the Lord's words will shine through though! First John chapter four says it clearly! God is love!" She turned to the crowd and shouted it so loud she thought her throat might tear but she felt like if she didn't declare this, she'd die. "God is love *and there is no fear in love!"* Adora held her other hand to Catra as she went on. "Before God and man I say there is no fear in love and I love this woman with no fear!"

Joshua started to step up and Adora fixed her eyes on him. There was anger on his face and before she would have fallen away from that anger. She'd been afraid of him since she'd met him, she'd been afraid of so many things, of judgment from him, from her mother, from everyone, and had felt small before it all. Even now, she could feel the need to apologize rising up and the urge to make herself small to gain favor but she felt the love in her, she felt the burning fire from the kiss on the dock and as Joshua reached to grab her arm, Adora stepped forward and forced him backwards.

"Do not touch me! Get thee behind me!"

Adora watched Joshua step back, frozen into inaction by the wrath pouring off Adora as she turned to Catra.

“We’re leaving now,” Adora said, her voice strong as she stepped around Joshua, took Catra’s hand, and began to walk.

Adora heard Joshua screaming about how dare she defy him and how she better get back if she knew what was good for her but she knew what was good for her and she held the hand of the person that personified that good and walked on into the shadows of the evening and feared no evil.

Chapter End Notes

I was reading an annotation of The Truth by Terry Pratchett and was reminded of John 8:32, "And ye shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free" and immediately thought, "Damn it! I should have put that in the climax of Camp Horde for the Lord!"

Then it occurred to me that I could just, you know, do a rewrite if I wanted and tack it on the end as supplemental material. So I did!

Which do I prefer? Well, I can tell the difference between my writing then and my writing now but honestly, I think they're both good. This fic has had so much genuine emotion both in writing it and in its reception that it almost feels wrong to change it but I thought this would be an interesting exercise so I went ahead and did it. I love them both for what they both are and I hope you do as well.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!